Mixed Migration Centre

Navigating new corridors:

the evolving route of Bangladeshi migration to Italy through Libya

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Mixed Migration Centre

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS OF DENMARK

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Libya - February 16. A top view of the former Basque fishing boat Aita Mari belonging to the Spanish NGO SMH (Humanitarian Maritime Rescue), which rescued 43 people (40 from Bangladesh, one from Sudan and two from Egypt), in the Libyan SAR zone (Central Mediterranean) as the sun rose in the Central Mediterranean in Libya on February 16, 2024. The rescued people were in good health and had left Zuwarah's coast (Libya) by boat just over 30 hours previously. A few minutes after the rescue, the Italian authorities announced that the intended destination of the rescued people was the Port of Ortona (Italy), more than 1,200 km from the rescue area.

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Written and researched by: Arezo Malakooti. Arezo Malakooti is an independent consultant specialising in migration systems analysis.

Reviewers: Roberto Forin, Bram Frouws

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List of Acronyms

BMET	Bureau of Manpower, Employment and Training
BRAC	Bangladesh Rural Advancement Committee
DTM	Displacement Tracking Matrix
EU	European Union
GCC	Gulf Cooperation Council
IDI	In-Depth Interviews
IOM	International Organisation for Migration
KII	Key Informant Interview
LNA	Libyan National Army
MMC	Mixed Migration Centre
MoEWOE	Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment
UAE	United Arab Emirates
USD	United States Dollar

1. Executive summary

Bangladesh has long relied on overseas labour migration as a pillar of its economic and social landscape. Millions of households depend on remittances for stability, mobility, and long-term security, and migration has become deeply embedded in national development pathways. In this context, Libya and Italy have re-emerged in recent years as increasingly significant destinations within a wider ecosystem of regular and irregular movement. Although migration to the Gulf and Malaysia continues to dominate in scale, the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy corridor has evolved into one of the most organised and adaptive routes linking South Asia to Europe.

This study examines the architecture and operational logic of that corridor. Based on 80 qualitative interviews across Bangladesh, Libya, and Italy, it addresses an important evidence gap: how Bangladeshi migrants reach Italy through Libya, how intermediaries and facilitators structure their journeys, and how risk and exploitation accumulate along the way. What emerges is a route defined not by rupture but by continuity. It is a system that extends Bangladesh's long-standing labour migration infrastructure into irregular terrain when formal opportunities shrink.

A continuum of profiles: from planning to deception to exploitation

Movement along this corridor reflects six interconnected profiles, representing gradations of agency, constraint, and vulnerability:

1. **Planned labour migrants,** who enter Libya through semi-regular channels to work.
2. **Italy aspirants,** who travel intentionally to Libya to continue to Europe.
3. **Debt-driven reroute migrants,** whose failed or costly regular migration to the Gulf pushes them toward Europe.
4. **Deceived migrants,** who are misled about their destination and find themselves in Libya unknowingly.
5. **Trafficked migrants,** who fall into debt bondage, forced labour, or resale between brokers in Libya.
6. **Returnees or escapees,** who attempt to flee Libya after cycles of violence, extortion, or detention.

These profiles are not discrete categories but points along a continuum. Migrants may move from planning to deception, from smuggling to exploitation, and from agency to coercion depending on circumstances. This continuum forms the analytical framework of the study and underscores how vulnerability is produced and compounded throughout the migration process.

Structural pressures and recalibrated opportunity

Bangladesh's reliance on overseas employment is increasingly shaped by economic deterioration, rising inflation, underemployment, and disillusionment with Gulf migration, which is widely perceived as exploitative, debt-inducing, and offering little long-term mobility. At the same time, Italy exerts a strong motivational pull. Its large Bangladeshi diaspora, past regularisation campaigns, and reputation for eventual stability and belonging create a sense that Italy offers a path to both livelihood and transformation. These narratives circulate through family networks and social reputation, reinforcing migration as a collective household strategy rather than an individual decision.

Shrinking access to regular pathways amplifies these pressures. Prospective migrants frequently begin with the intention to migrate legally, approaching recruitment agencies or applying for visas, but are steered toward irregular options by the same intermediaries they rely on for information and documentation. In Bangladesh's dense recruitment ecosystem, the distinction between regular and irregular channels quickly collapses in practice because the actors, processes, and paperwork frequently overlap. This study finds that irregular migration to Italy is often the final stage of an attempted legal migration process rather than an alternative to it.

Eastern Libya as the organising centre of the route

Since 2020, a semi-formal entry system in eastern Libya has become the backbone of the corridor. Under this system, migrants enter Benghazi legally using entry clearances issued by the Libyan National Army's Military Investment Authority. This structure has reshaped the entire corridor:

- **Recruitment in Bangladesh** is organised around delivering migrants directly into eastern Libya with valid passports, visas, and flight itineraries that mirror regular labour migration.
- **Transit routes** through Dubai, Egypt, Kuwait, Turkey, India, or Sri Lanka function as feeder systems designed to synchronise documentation, verify payments, and route groups into Benghazi.
- **Arrival in Benghazi** initiates a structured sequence of registration, health screening, nationality-segregated holding sites, and coordinated transportation across the country.

Initially established for Syrians through Cham Wings Airlines, the eastern system has been increasingly dominated by Bangladeshi arrivals. In its early phase, migrants entering Benghazi were moved to Tobruk, where boats departed directly from the eastern coast toward Italy. This changed in 2023 when increased scrutiny and selective enforcement in the east made Tobruk departures less feasible. As conditions shifted, networks adapted by redirecting migrants from Benghazi to the western coastal hubs of Zuwara and Zawiya, which became the main points of departure to Italy. Despite this relocation of the final leg, eastern Libya remained the organising centre of the route.

A modular, multi-layered network across three regions

The Bangladesh–Libya–Italy corridor functions through a segmented structure in which different actors control specific parts of the journey.

- **Brokers in Bangladesh** handle recruitment, documentation, fee negotiation, and communication with families.
- **Transit facilitators** based in the UAE, Egypt, Kuwait, Turkey, India, and Sri Lanka coordinate group movement and manage handovers between networks.
- **Libyan actors,** including airport sponsors, armed groups, drivers, and coastal smugglers, regulate movement inside Libya and control access to onward travel.

These actors are linked through communication channels, trust-based relationships, and shared financial arrangements. Movement inside Libya follows a chain of negotiated hubs — from Benghazi in the east, through Ajdabiya, Sirte, and Shwerayif, to the coastal centres of Zuwara and Zawiya — with responsibility passing from one facilitator to the next.

This segmented architecture enables rapid adaptation to political and enforcement shifts. When restrictions increased in eastern Libya at the end of 2023, networks redirected migrants to the western coast for departure to Italy, ensuring that the overall flow continued even as operational routes changed.

A protection economy built on predictability and coercion

Bangladeshi migrants are uniquely targeted for extortion due to their strong family support networks, which make them reliable payers. The result is a protection economy in which financial extraction occurs at every stage:

- confiscation of wages or documents;
- inflated fees for food, security, or onward travel;
- staged or genuine kidnappings for ransom;
- periods of captivity in holding sites or "game houses";

- forced labour during delays or detention;
- resale between brokers.

These practices reflect a continuum between smuggling and trafficking rather than two distinct systems. Migrants frequently transition from one to the other depending on debt, payment failure, or capture by armed groups. The purpose of exploitation, whether through labour, ransom, or coercion, is embedded in the operational logic of the route. Even interception at sea does not end the cycle. Many migrants are handed back to Bangladeshi intermediaries along the western coast and forced to pay again for release or onward movement.

The economics of the system

The study finds that the route operates through standardised price tiers. Most Bangladeshis pay between **USD 10,000–14,000** for the full journey from Bangladesh to Italy, with many ultimately spending **USD 15,000–17,000** after extortion and additional costs inside Libya. Using 2024 arrival figures in Italy as the baseline and applying these documented price structures across scenario-based models, the estimated size of the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy smuggling economy is **USD 160–190 million per year**. This represents a **lower-bound estimate**, excluding those who paid but never arrived in Italy. These revenues sustain actors across the route's layered architecture and reinforce the economic incentives underlying the system.

Key insights

- **Irregular migration is the adaptive extension of Bangladesh's formal labour migration system.** When regular pathways become costly, slow, or inaccessible, the same brokers, documentation channels, and trust structures shift into informal terrain.
- **Eastern Libya's semi-formal entry system serves as the organising centre of the corridor**, structuring recruitment at origin, transit flows, and onward movement across Libya.
- **The distinction between regular and irregular migration collapses in practice.** Migrants often begin through legal channels but are redirected into irregular pathways by intermediaries who manipulate both formal procedures and social trust.
- **Protection risks are systemic, not incidental.** Extortion, ransom, and exploitation are integral components of the route's political economy, sustained by armed groups and facilitated by Bangladeshi intermediaries.
- **Smuggling and trafficking form a continuum**, shaped by debt, coercion, and the resale of migrants between actors.
- **The network is segmented, resilient, and highly adaptive**, responding rapidly to enforcement dynamics in Libya and enabling continuous flows.
- **The smuggling economy is large and economically structured**, generating at least USD 160–190 million annually and reinforcing the financial incentives that drive the system.
- **Effective governance must address the entire route**, from recruitment ecosystems in Bangladesh to the hybrid governance structures in Libya and the integration environment in Italy.

2. Introduction

Bangladesh is one of the most significant countries of origin within the global migration landscape, with millions of its citizens seeking opportunities abroad through both regular and irregular means. Overseas employment has long been a defining feature of Bangladesh's development trajectory, supporting household incomes and national growth through remittances. Today, the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries and Southeast Asia remain the primary destinations for Bangladeshi labour migrants. However, Libya and Italy have also formed part of this broader migration landscape for decades.

In recent years, Bangladeshi nationals have consistently ranked among the top nationalities arriving irregularly in Italy, particularly via the Central Mediterranean Route. Although this corridor remains small compared to established labour migration channels to the Gulf and Malaysia, it has become an increasingly visible and organised pathway to Europe. This trend has been enabled by the emergence of a hybrid migration system in Libya, in which formal entry and residence mechanisms coexist with irregular onward movement. Within this system, migrants are able to enter Libya through semi-regular channels but subsequently rely on smuggling networks to reach Italy.

At the same time, socioeconomic pressures in Bangladesh have intensified, marked by rising unemployment, high living costs, and limited diversification of the domestic labour market. In parallel, disillusionment with regular migration pathways to the Gulf and Malaysia, often characterised by debt, exploitation, and restricted mobility, has affected their appeal. These overlapping dynamics have created fertile ground for brokers and intermediaries to promote the Libya–Italy route as a viable and desirable alternative.

Italy is perceived as a destination where migrants can aspire not only to better economic opportunities but also to a greater sense of dignity and long-term security. Stories of regularization through past campaigns, family reunification, and social mobility within Italy's large Bangladeshi diaspora have strengthened its image as a country where hard work can eventually lead to stability and belonging. For many aspiring migrants, Italy represents an escape from the exploitative yet legal systems of Gulf migration, embodying the possibility of both livelihood and transformation.

In light of the growing number of Bangladeshi migrants arriving in Italy via Libya, this report seeks to examine the mechanisms underpinning this movement and to address a critical evidence gap. Despite the visibility of this corridor, little is known about how Bangladeshi migrants reach Italy, or about the actors and processes that facilitate their journeys. This study therefore explores the motivations, journey planning, facilitation networks, financial arrangements, and protection risks that shape this evolving migration system. By mapping these interconnected dimensions across origin, transit, and destination contexts, the report contributes to a more comprehensive understanding of one of the most complex and underexplored migration corridors linking South Asia and the Central Mediterranean.

3. Methodology

3.1 Objectives

While recent years have seen a sharp rise in the number of Bangladeshi nationals arriving irregularly in Italy, there remains a critical evidence gap regarding the mechanisms underpinning this movement—from motivations and journey planning to facilitation networks, financial arrangements, and protection risks. In response, this research adopts a holistic approach that goes beyond quantitative trends to explore the lived experiences, decisions, and systems shaping the migration process.

The specific objectives of this study are:

1. **Map Routes, Modalities, and Protection Risks**
   Primary migration routes and pathways used by Bangladeshi migrants to reach Italy, including associated risks faced during different phases of the journey.

2. **Identify Drivers and Decision-Making Factors**
   Underlying motivations behind Bangladeshi migration to Italy as well as the factors that influence some to migrate regularly and others to migrate irregularly.

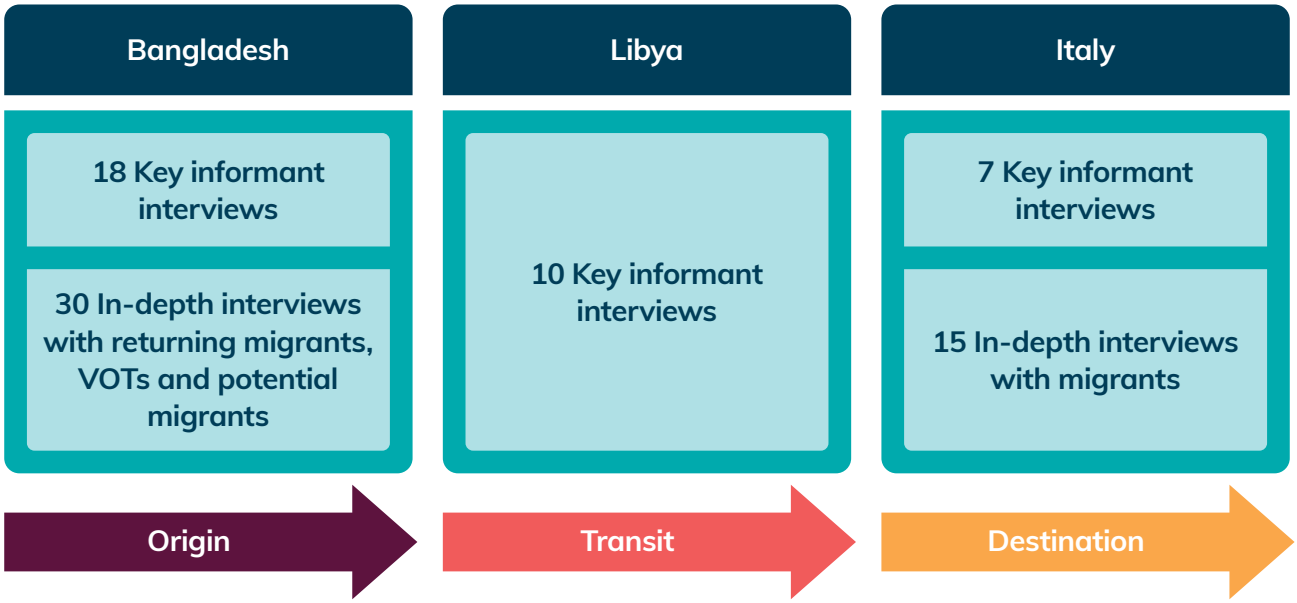
3. **Examine the Role of Intermediaries and Facilitation Networks**
   To assess how migration is facilitated and monetized.

4. **Intentions and Onward Movements**
   To examine how initial migration intentions evolve throughout the journey.

5. **Generate Policy- and Programming-Relevant Insights**
   To develop practical, evidence-based recommendations for policymakers for more effective, humane, and context-specific migration governance.

3.2 Approach

Figure 1. Methodology



The analysis is informed by 80 qualitative interviews conducted across three countries: Bangladesh, Libya and Italy. A total of 35 Key informant interviews were distributed across Bangladesh (18), Libya (10), and Italy (7); and 45 in-depth interviews with migrants and potential migrants were distributed across Bangladesh (30) and Italy (15).

This study employs a three-module qualitative research design consisting of: (i) a desk review of existing literature, policy documents, and quantitative datasets related to Bangladeshi migration; (ii) Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) with stakeholders across Bangladesh, Libya, and Italy; and (iii) In-Depth Interviews (IDIs) with Bangladeshi migrants, returnees, and potential migrants. Grounded in a route-based framework, the methodology follows the migration journey across countries of origin, transit, and destination, enabling analysis at multiple levels along the migration continuum. This design links structural and institutional dynamics with the lived experiences of migrants themselves, providing an integrated understanding of how decisions, risks, and opportunities evolve across the route.

Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) were conducted with stakeholders across Bangladesh, Libya, and Italy, including representatives of NGOs, UN agencies, research institutions, local authorities, and security actors. These interviews generated insights into policy environments, protection challenges, and operational realities surrounding irregular migration.

In-Depth Interviews (IDIs) were carried out with Bangladeshi migrants (In Italy), returnees and potential migrants (in Bangladesh) focusing on individual experiences and decision-making processes along the migration continuum. The interviews were designed to allow for open, reflective dialogue, enabling participants to narrate their journeys in detail and at their own pace. Discussions explored motivations to migrate, access to information, recruitment and financing arrangements, experiences during transit and stay in Libya, and outcomes following arrival in Italy. This in-depth and conversational approach allowed the research to capture both the emotional texture and the structural realities of migration, revealing how aspiration, coercion, and adaptation intersect in shaping mobility decisions.

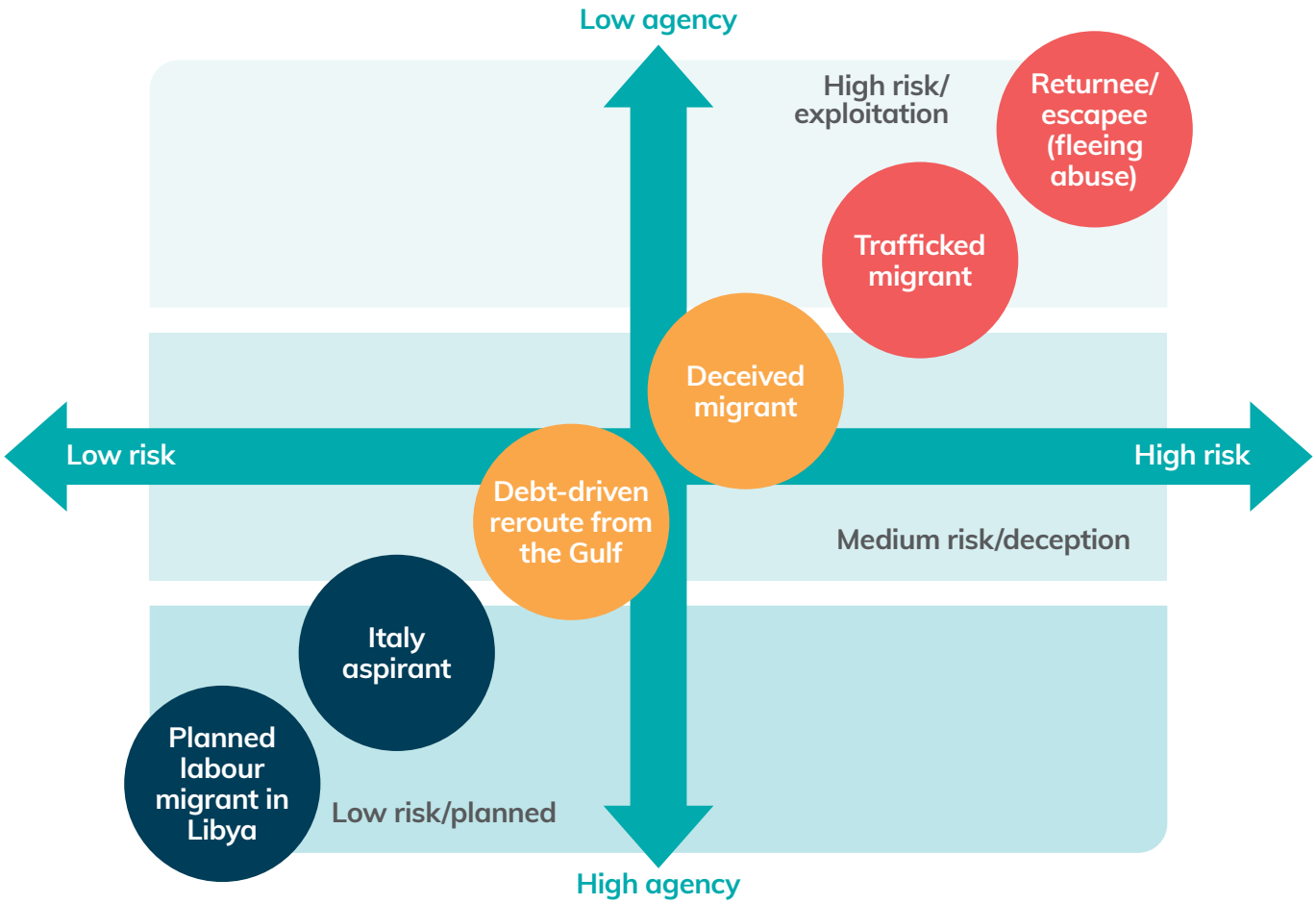
Together, KIIs and IDIs enabled the study to **triangulate data across structural, institutional, and human levels**, linking macro-level systems with micro-level experience. The research design adhered to strict ethical standards, ensuring confidentiality, voluntary participation, and sensitivity to protection concerns, particularly in contexts involving trauma, detention, or exploitation.

In addition to the interviews conducted for this study, the analysis incorporates **insights generated through the author's long-standing field research** on smuggling economies and mobility systems in Libya, undertaken over multiple research cycles since 2011.

4. Profiles

This research reveals that Bangladeshi migration to and through Libya is not a single, uniform phenomenon but rather a spectrum of experiences shaped by differing levels of agency, information, and exposure to risk. Migrants' pathways vary according to how informed their decisions are, the degree of deception they encounter, and the conditions they face along the route. These diverse trajectories can be charted across a continuum of vulnerability, ranging from low-risk or planned migration, where individuals travel to Libya through relatively structured channels with valid documents and clear intentions to work there; to medium-risk or deceptive journeys, where misinformation and financial pressure push migrants into irregularity; and finally to high-risk or exploitative experiences, where individuals are subjected to trafficking and forced labour.

Figure 2. Migrant profiles according to levels of agency and risk



4.1 Low risk/planned

4.1.1 Planned labour migrant in Libya

This profile represents the least vulnerable group within the spectrum of Bangladeshi migration to Libya. These migrants travel from Bangladesh with the intention of working legally in Libya, often through semi-formal or formal labour channels, and without plans for onward movement to Europe. Their journeys are comparatively structured and better resourced, reflecting a higher degree of agency and informed decision-making than other profiles in this study.

Historically, labour mobility schemes between the Bangladeshi and Libyan governments (see Figure 3**) enabled official recruitment and placement,** channeling arrivals primarily to western Libya, where the internationally recognised government and its labour administration are based. In recent years, however, an increasing number of Bangladeshi workers have entered through eastern Libya, drawn by reconstruction activities under the Libyan National Army (LNA), which have generated a demand for foreign labour and an alternative system of entry.

According to IOM's Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM), in 2024, only 11 per cent of Bangladeshi migrants in Libya reported using migration facilitators to reach the country. The majority stated that they held valid passports and work permits, suggesting entry through relatively regular channels. Among those employed, 87 per cent reported having permanent or fixed-term contracts, which is higher than the rate for all migrants in Libya (78 per cent). These findings suggest two distinct Bangladeshi populations in Libya: one that migrates to work and remains (captured by DTM statistics), and another that transits Libya for irregular onward movement to Italy (most likely not captured by DTM).

While this group faces fewer risks than others in the spectrum, it is important to recognise that the risk of exploitation, wage theft, kidnapping, and poor living conditions remain common. What distinguishes this profile is not the absence of vulnerability, but the relative predictability and stability of their migration experience compared to those who enter Libya irregularly or are deceived along the way. Their journeys tend to be self-financed—through family savings or modest loans—and largely insulated from the high-risk smuggling networks that dominate the Libya–Italy corridor.

However, as the profiles presented later in this section demonstrate, even planned and documented migration can deteriorate under the pressures of Libya's volatile security environment and governance gaps. Several migrants who initially entered Libya through regular channels ultimately found themselves trapped in cycles of abuse or extortion, prompting their eventual departure. These experiences are explored in greater depth in the "Returnee/ Escapee" profile that concludes this spectrum.

4.1.2 Italy aspirant

This profile consists primarily of young men who travel from Bangladesh to Libya with the explicit aim of reaching Italy. They represent the more mobile end of the low-risk category: migrants whose journeys unfold largely according to plan, even within an inherently volatile and dangerous environment. Since 2022, most have entered through eastern Libya, taking advantage of the relatively open visa and entry system that has emerged under the Libyan National Army (LNA), detailed in subsequent sections.

In DTM Europe's 2024 Flow Monitoring Survey, Bangladeshi respondents were primarily surveyed in Italy, reflecting their strong presence among arrivals on both the Central Mediterranean and Western Balkans-Italy routes. The Bangladesh-specific profile shows a highly consistent demographic pattern: all respondents were men, and nearly three-quarters were aged 18–29. Many reported lower-secondary education and previous employment before departure, with most having worked in sectors such as agriculture and construction. Economic motivations dominated their migration decisions, cited by roughly three-quarters of Bangladeshi respondents (76–78%). The concentration of Bangladeshi interviews in Italy, together with the profiles of those surveyed there, underscores Italy's central role as the main point of arrival and primary destination among Bangladeshi migrants captured in the 2024 FMS.

Figure 3. Timeline of Libya-Bangladesh MOUs for labour migration

2008	First manpower MOU signed, enabling large-scale recruitment for Libya's development push
2009	Libya's public-works drive created strong demand; number of Bangladeshis in Libya rose markedly under the 2008 framework
2010	Around 40,000 Bangladeshis went to Libya from 2008-10, then Libya imposed a recruitment ban on Bangladesh in June 2010
2011	The revolution of 2011 interrupted regular channels; large evacuations of Bangladeshi workers from Libya
2012	Bangladesh stopped sending workers to Libya in May 2012 amid instability
2015	Libya's (Tobruk) authorities banned Bangladeshi workers in May 2015
2016	Bangladesh (2016) instructed nationals not to work in Libya due to security risks
2023	New MOU "Joint Cooperation in the Field of Recruitment of Workers" reopens the path for formal recruitment

Interviews for this study reinforce these patterns and demonstrate that the majority came from close-knit family structures in which migration decisions were collective. Fathers or older male relatives typically negotiated with brokers and financed the journey. Migration was therefore not an individual act of risk-taking but a family project to secure long-term stability. Unlike Gulf migration, which is temporary and cyclical, movement towards Europe is perceived as permanent. These migrants are generally educated enough to aspire to better opportunities abroad but lack the qualifications to access regular migration channels.

While their journeys are considered the smoothest within this spectrum, they are far from risk-free. Even those who move quickly through Libya must navigate territories controlled by armed groups, repeated checkpoints, and widespread extortion. Passage from eastern to western Libya exposes them to the same networks of coercion and rent extraction that entrap others for far longer. Their crossings to Italy, which are usually by sea from the western coast, remain highly perilous. However, compared to other profiles, they face fewer unexpected disruptions and a higher likelihood of arrival. In this sense, the Italy Aspirant embodies the most "successful" iteration of a high-risk system, where relative luck, timing, and connections reduce, but never eliminate, the dangers of the route.

4.2 Medium risk/deception

4.2.1 Debt-driven reroute

This profile captures migrants whose irregular journey to Europe originates in financial distress and unmet expectations from earlier labour migration experiences elsewhere. Many first migrate legally to the Gulf, investing heavily in recruitment, documentation, and travel. Once abroad, they often discover that promised salaries or conditions fall far short of expectations, leaving them unable to recover their costs. Debt then becomes a key driver of onward migration, turning economic frustration into renewed mobility.

While still abroad, particularly in cities such as Dubai, some of these migrants are approached by intermediaries offering "European jobs." Disillusioned by low wages and restrictive contracts, they see these offers as their only chance to escape debt and achieve the prosperity they originally sought. Smugglers exploit this vulnerability, marketing onward movement to Libya as a legitimate or inevitable next step toward Europe.

Others return to Bangladesh after multiple unsuccessful migration attempts, determined to try again but this time to Europe directly. In both cases, the decision to move irregularly arises less from aspiration than from economic compulsion—a final attempt to resolve debts and meet family expectations after years of unfulfilled regular migration.

Across this profile, the boundary between voluntary choice and coercion is blurred. Migration decisions occur under severe financial pressure, and brokers deliberately frame Libya as the "next stage" in an otherwise familiar migration cycle, transforming vulnerability itself into a profitable market.

4.2.2 Deceived migrant

This profile encompasses those who embark on their journey from Bangladesh under false pretenses. Several respondents reported being told they were travelling to Kuwait or Malaysia for legitimate employment, only to discover mid-journey, or even upon arrival, that their destination was Libya. In some cases, migrants only realised this after landing in Egypt or during transit in Dubai, when facilitators confiscated their documents. In each case, deception began at the recruitment stage, by facilitators who exploited migrants' trust and limited knowledge of geography and travel procedures.

These migrants rarely have the intention to reach Europe at the outset. Their journeys to Libya are the product of misinformation and manipulation, exposing them to both debt and coercion. By the time they realise the deception, they are often already in transit; without valid visas for the countries they are passing through, without their passports, and fully embedded within the smuggling network. At that point, there is little possibility of withdrawal or seeking assistance. Continuing the journey becomes the only viable option, both because of practical constraints and the fear of financial ruin or social disgrace if they return home empty-handed.

While these journeys involve two of the constitutive elements of trafficking under the Palermo Protocol (the Act of transport and the Means of deception or abuse of vulnerability), they do not involve the third element, which is a purpose of exploitation. In this profile, the intent behind the deception is primarily to extract migration fees or transport migrants into Libya for onward smuggling, rather than to exploit their labour or body once in Libya. As such, although these migrants experience clear violations of their rights and significant coercion, their experiences do not constitute trafficking unless or until a purpose of exploitation emerges later along the route. This distinction is important, as many migrants who begin as deceived travellers only become trafficked once they fall into situations of forced labour, debt bondage, or other exploitative arrangements inside Libya, as described in the subsequent profile.

4.3 High risk/exploitation

4.3.1 Trafficked migrant

This profile reflects migrants who fall into debt bondage and labour exploitation once in Libya. Many enter without paying the full cost upfront, being told that they can settle the remainder after arrival or once they begin working. Instead, when they arrive, they are forced to work under the control of brokers or employers to repay inflated travel debts. Wages are withheld, movement restricted, and identity documents confiscated.
Others are promised specific jobs and salaries in Libya but are placed in exploitative conditions upon arrival: lower-paid, irregular work, or no pay at all. Some are even sold to other brokers or employers, illustrating the commodification of labour within Libya's broker-controlled economy.

These dynamics meet all three elements of the Palermo Protocol definition of trafficking: recruitment through deception, transport across borders under false promises, and exploitation through abuse of vulnerability and control of labour. Physical violence may not always be visible, but control is maintained through indebtedness, dependency, and fear. The full spectrum of trafficking risks is explored further in section 3.

4.3.2 Returnee/escapee

This final profile represents those who leave Libya, either towards Italy or back to Bangladesh, after enduring violence, insecurity, or repeated exploitation. Many arrived in Libya for work but faced continuous extortion by security forces, including arbitrary detention and ransom demands by police or militias.

One respondent described being arrested multiple times by police and forced to pay for release until he was destitute. Unable to return home due to debt and shame, he decided to attempt the sea crossing to Italy as an escape route rather than a planned migration. Others who manage to return to Bangladesh often do so through brokers after prolonged hardship, sometimes after contacting the same intermediaries who arranged their initial migration.

For these migrants, onward or return movement is not an act of opportunity but of survival: an attempt to flee a cycle of violence, exploitation, and debt from which formal protection mechanisms offer no relief.

5. Drivers of migration and decision-making

The decision of Bangladeshi migrants to undertake the journey to Libya, and onward to Italy, is rooted in a complex interplay of factors. Migration from Bangladesh does not arise from a single push or pull factor but from an ecosystem of intertwined drivers. At one end are the enduring structural realities: limited domestic employment, debt, and underemployment within a saturated labour market. At the other, are the compelling narratives of success emanating from the Bangladeshi diaspora in Italy. Between these poles lies a spectrum of individual and family motivations shaped by precarity, pride, and social mobility.

5.1 Push factors from Bangladesh

Bangladesh's high levels of outward migration are driven by a combination of structural economic constraints, demographic pressure, and declining domestic opportunities. Migration has become an integral part of the country's development model, sustained by limited job creation at home and deepening household reliance on remittances.

5.1.1 Migration as a structural feature of Bangladesh's economy

Bangladesh is one of the world's leading countries of origin for migrant labour, ranking sixth globally in 2020 with approximately 7.4 million nationals living abroad, equivalent to around 4.4 per cent of the population.[1] Labour migration has become a structural component of Bangladesh's economic and social fabric, deeply embedded in both national policy and household strategies. For decades, the country has relied on overseas employment to manage labour-market surpluses, reduce unemployment, and generate remittances. These remittances play a stabilising role in macroeconomic management, supporting household consumption, savings, and foreign-exchange reserves.[2]

5.1.2 Structural limitations and domestic labour market constraints

Despite sustained growth over the past two decades, the Bangladeshi economy remains unable to absorb its rapidly expanding workforce. The domestic labour market is heavily concentrated in low-wage, low-productivity sectors, particularly in garment manufacturing, construction, and informal services. Employment creation has not kept pace with population growth, and underemployment remains widespread, especially among young people and rural populations. Over time, migration has evolved from an individual pursuit into a systemic livelihood strategy, embedded in social expectations and intergenerational planning.[3]

5.1.3 Economic deterioration and intensifying migration pressures

Recent macroeconomic deterioration has intensified these structural drivers. According to the European Union Agency for Asylum (EUAA), Bangladesh's GDP growth fell from 5.1 per cent in 2024 to 3.3 per cent in early 2025, due to political unrest, reduced investor confidence, and constrained fiscal capacity. The International Crisis Group, cited in the same report, attributes these challenges to economic mismanagement, corruption, and cronyism. Simultaneously, high inflation, a balance-of-payments deficit, and declining foreign-exchange reserves have eroded purchasing power and weakened domestic employment conditions. Protests in mid-2024 further disrupted supply chains and exports, especially in the garment sector, compounding the sense of economic fragility. Interviews conducted for this study mirror these findings: several migrants described failed attempts to improve their livelihoods through local business ventures or agriculture, leading to debt accumulation and renewed pressure to seek opportunities abroad.[4]

1 International Organization for Migration (IOM) (2020) *World Migration Report 2020: Bangladesh Country Profile*, IOM, Geneva.
2 Migration Policy Institute (MPI) (2024) *Bangladesh: Migration and Remittances Profile 2024*.
3 United Nations Capital Development Fund (UNCDF) (2023) *Bangladesh Country Assessment: The Role of Migrant Money in Financial Inclusion*, UNCDF, New York.
4 European Union Agency for Asylum (EUAA) (2025) *Country of Origin Information Report: Bangladesh – Country Focus*, August 2025.

5.1.4 Diversification of migration routes under structural pressure

Within this context, migration has become not merely an option but an economic necessity. Each year, an estimated 500,000 Bangladeshis migrate for overseas employment, primarily to Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries and Southeast Asia.[5] However, as opportunities in these regions narrow—due to restrictive visa policies, recruitment monopolies, and rising migration costs - migrants are increasingly diversifying their destinations. While migration to Italy and other parts of Europe is not new, it has gained increased prominence in this context. Thus, migration toward Italy today represents not the emergence of a new trend, but the reconfiguration of an existing one: an adaptive response within Bangladesh's long-established migration system, where structural pressures, household debt, and aspirational narratives continue to sustain outward mobility.

5.1.5 Economic vulnerability as a gateway to exploitation

This pervasive sense of precarity renders potential migrants highly susceptible to recruitment narratives that promise quick success abroad. Brokers and intermediaries exploit these structural vulnerabilities, presenting migration as the only viable route to economic progress. In doing so, they convert systemic unemployment and disillusionment into individualised motivation, ensuring a continuous supply of new clients for irregular migration networks.

5.2 Pull factors to Italy

Italy exerts a strong and multi-layered pull on prospective Bangladeshi migrants, shaped by a combination of historical opportunity, social aspiration, and practical accessibility. While the decision to migrate often begins as a response to economic hardship, Italy's particular appeal lies in its reputation as both a land of opportunity and a more humane alternative to Gulf migration.

5.2.1 Perceived opportunities and legal precedents

Many respondents cited Italy's past regularisation campaigns as a key influence on their migration decisions. Stories of undocumented migrants who later obtained residence permits and secured stable employment circulate widely through Bangladeshi communities, fuelling the belief that Italy remains accessible even to those who arrive irregularly. These narratives create a sense of possibility, an impression that Italy offers "a second chance" unavailable elsewhere in Europe.

This perception also has tangible effects in Bangladesh. Loans are reportedly easier to obtain when borrowers declare that the funds are for migration to Europe, particularly to Italy, because lenders view such journeys as more profitable and more likely to result in remittances. In this sense, Italy's reputation enhances both financial access and social legitimacy for potential migrants.

5.2.2 Diaspora networks and informal recruitment

The long-established Bangladeshi diaspora in Italy reinforces these pull dynamics. While the United Kingdom hosts the largest Bangladeshi community in Europe's broader region, Italy now has the largest Bangladeshi diaspora within the European Union, with networks extending across major cities such as Rome, Milan, and Naples. Within these enclaves, migrants can live and work using only Bangla, with minimal need for Italian or English. This linguistic and cultural familiarity lowers the psychological and practical barriers to entry, making Italy appear uniquely navigable among European destinations.

Diaspora-based businesses also play a recruitment role. Bangladeshi entrepreneurs who run restaurants, retail shops, and small enterprises in Italy often rely on relatives and acquaintances from Bangladesh to expand their workforce. These arrangements are mutually beneficial: employers secure trusted workers, while newly arrived migrants gain immediate access to income and accommodation. In some cases, employers also receive a payment from relatives in

5 European Union Agency for Asylum (EUAA) (2025) Country of Origin Information Report: Bangladesh – Country Focus, August 2025.

Bangladesh for facilitating the recruitment—a form of transnational patronage that deepens community ties while perpetuating informal migration chains.

5.2.3 Italy as an alternative to Gulf migration

For many migrants, Italy's appeal lies less in the concrete promises of specific jobs or earnings and more in the impression that it can offer these things. After decades of labour migration to the Gulf, stories of long hours, low wages, and harsh conditions have become deeply embedded in collective memory. These experiences have shaped a widespread perception that Gulf migration offers survival but not dignity or long-term mobility. By contrast, Italy is imagined as a place where personal freedom, fairer labour conditions, and the possibility of regularisation are at least attainable, even if uncertain. As one migrant explained: "In my village, many people went legally to Saudi Arabia or Qatar, but I knew the stories. I did not want that life. Italy seemed like the only door left open to me.

It is important to note that this is an aspirational view rather than a reflection of actual conditions for irregular migrants in Italy. Interviews conducted in Italy show that many encounter precarity, underemployment, and ongoing vulnerability upon arrival. Nevertheless, the *perception* of Italy as offering a pathway, however difficult, toward stability and social mobility continues to differentiate it sharply from the Gulf experience and plays a significant role in shaping migration decisions.

5.2.4 Social mobility and family aspirations

Italy's pull is also reinforced by the social prestige attached to migration to Europe. Success abroad translates into elevated family status at home, influencing marriage prospects and social standing. Families frequently express pride in having sons in Europe, and young men note that "Europe migrants" are considered the most eligible bachelors in their communities.

Moreover, candidates often cite the possibility of family reunification and citizenship in Europe as decisive advantages over the Gulf, where migration is strictly temporary and excludes dependents. The impression that Italy provides the ability to settle, gain permanent residence, and eventually bring one's family to Europe amplifies its long-term appeal and frames it as a pathway to transformation rather than mere employment.

5.3 Journey planning

For many Bangladeshi migrants interviewed, the process of planning a journey was rarely self-directed. Rather, it evolved through interactions with brokers, relatives, or community members who presented migration as both achievable and desirable. Social networks, like friends, neighbours, and returnees, were central conduits for information and access to *dalals*[6] and travel agents.

5.3.1 From regular intentions to irregular pathways

Several respondents initially sought legitimate means of travel, often approaching licensed recruitment agencies in search of employment visas for Gulf countries or Europe. In numerous accounts, brokers or agency representatives informed them that obtaining a visa through regular channels was "not possible," before offering an alternative irregular route. Through this pivot, the broker effectively transformed a regular migration aspiration into an irregular one, framing the latter as the only viable pathway to reach Europe. These conversations reveal how irregular migration is often introduced under the guise of professional recruitment, exploiting the limited availability of legal options and the widespread trust placed in local agents.

6 local middlemen who act as brokers between aspiring migrants and formal recruitment offices. Explained in more detail in the next section of the report.

5.3.2 Social influence and opportunistic recruitment

In many cases, migration plans began with casual encounters rather than deliberate search. Some migrants were first approached by intermediaries in informal community settings such as tea stalls, mosques, or local markets. These brokers observed and identified potential clients, often young men facing unemployment or financial difficulty, and used persuasive narratives to encourage migration. By presenting migration as an attainable escape from hardship, brokers tapped into pre-existing frustration and social aspiration. The line between suggestion and recruitment was thin: what started as a conversation over tea could evolve into a commitment involving thousands of dollars and a perilous transcontinental journey.

In some cases, the approach came not from a local broker but from a friend already living in Italy who had previously made the journey. Initially, this contact appeared to be offering advice or assistance, but it later became clear that such friends were in fact working with smugglers and had become part of the broader facilitation network. Their role was to build trust and legitimacy by presenting themselves as successful migrants, while in reality they were serving as intermediaries connecting new clients to the same networks that had arranged their own journeys.

5.3.3 "Shopping around" and the engineered use of "success stories"

Certain localities in Bangladesh, such as Shariapour, Madipour, Poritpour, and Kishervans; are known as migration hubs where movement to Italy has become common. In these areas, there are multiple brokers operating side by side, giving prospective migrants several options to choose from. Within this environment, migrants often "shop around", seeking advice from friends and relatives already in Italy or Libya about which smugglers they used and how their journeys unfolded. They compare prices, routes, and reputations before deciding which broker to trust.

When migrants do not have relatives or friends abroad, they rely instead on neighbourhood networks, such as local returnees, acquaintances, and community figures, to identify brokers with a track record of success. This collective process of verification has become a defining feature of how journeys are planned in many migration-prone districts.

Smugglers have learned to anticipate this verification loop, and it now directly shapes their recruitment methods. Knowing that potential clients will seek proof of successful outcomes, they deliberately curate and deploy "success stories." They put would-be migrants on phone or video calls with people who have recently reached Italy, send photos and voice messages from Europe, or claim, "my own son is in Italy," to create a sense of credibility and personal connection. These narratives are designed to pre-empt doubt and inspire confidence at the exact moment when migrants are comparing options. In this way, the "success story" has become a marketing tool- an engineered device to convert verification into persuasion.

5.3.4 Trust, familiarity, and local legitimacy

A recurring theme in the interviews was the degree of trust migrants placed in brokers from their own locality. Many respondents emphasised that they were more inclined to believe someone from their village or neighbourhood than an "official" or government representative. This familiarity, often reinforced by kinship or long-standing social ties, endowed brokers with local legitimacy and made their promises more persuasive. Even when migrants had doubts about the legality of the journey, the broker's personal connection or community reputation often outweighed these concerns.

5.3.5 Family involvement

Families play a decisive role in the planning and organisation of migration journeys. Many migrants reported that their fathers, rather than themselves, were the primary negotiators with smugglers. Fathers often handled the financial arrangements, collected information, and made final decisions about which broker to engage. This reflects both the family's collective investment in migration and the intergenerational nature of migration decision-making in rural Bangladesh. Migration is rarely an individual choice; it is a family project undertaken in the hope of improving household welfare.

5.3.6 Online recruitment and the digital marketplace

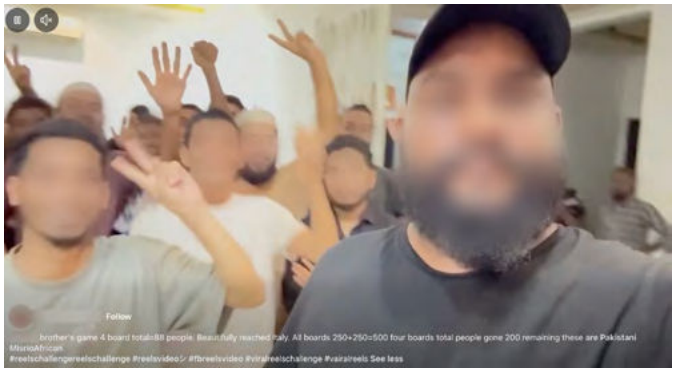
Sometimes, initial contact is made online. A minority of respondents described finding facilitators through Facebook pages or posts such as "a boat is going on this day, call us," and then moving to private messaging to discuss prices and logistics. These exchanges often take place on 'Imo', a popular messaging platform among Bangladeshi communities. Smugglers use it to communicate directly with prospective migrants, share updates, and negotiate arrangements. Although online facilitation is not widespread, this digital channel offers smugglers a discreet and low-risk way to reach potential clients and transition conversations into offline negotiations.

5.3.7 Duration and logistics of journey preparation

Once the decision to migrate has been made, the organisation of the journey tends to move quickly. Most respondents reported that it takes between one week and one month from the time they meet the smuggler and agree to proceed until their actual departure from Bangladesh. This short preparation period reflects the high level of organisation within smuggling networks and the efficiency with which logistics are arranged once payment is secured.

Typically, the migrant already possesses a valid passport, which is handed over to the smuggler as soon as an agreement is reached. The smuggler then manages all travel arrangements, including the visa acquisition and purchase of plane tickets, often through links with travel agents or facilitators who handle the necessary documentation. During this period, communication between the smuggler and migrant usually continues on Imo, allowing for coordination of departure dates, flight details, and handover points. This streamlined process, which can take place in as little as a few days, gives migrants the impression of a highly functional and reliable operation, further reinforcing their confidence in the smuggler's capacity to deliver on promises.

Figure 4. Advertising by smugglers on Facebook





6. Routes of travel and smuggling dynamics

The UN Protocol against the Smuggling of Migrants by Land, Sea and Air (2000) defines smuggling as "*the procurement, in order to obtain, directly or indirectly, a financial or other material benefit, of the illegal entry of a person into a State Party of which the person is not a national or a permanent resident.*"

This definition highlights three core elements:

1. Facilitation by a third party;
2. Irregular entry into a state; and
3. The procurement of a financial or material benefit.

However, the mechanics of Bangladeshi migration to Libya and onward to Europe require a broader analytical lens. In line with MMC's approach, this report adopts an expanded understanding of smuggling that reflects how migrants themselves perceive the actors and activities that shape their journeys. MMC uses the terms smuggler and smuggling to describe a wide range of services, paid for or otherwise compensated, that facilitate irregular migration. These include the irregular crossing of international borders or internal checkpoints, but also the provision of services such as documentation, transport, accommodation, and logistical coordination. Importantly, MMC's interpretation is deliberately broader than the UN Protocol's legal definition, and does not imply that all such activities constitute criminal offences. Rather, it captures the practical realities and facilitation arrangements as experienced and described by migrants.

Applying this dual lens is critical in the Bangladeshi context. In practice, not all journeys involve illegal border crossings, and not all facilitators engaged in the process fit the legal definition of a smuggler. Within Bangladeshi migration systems, there exists a spectrum of actors: smugglers who profit directly from organising irregular travel, including onward maritime movement; and facilitators who operate within broader network to arrange tdocumentation, flights, accommodation, or handovers, without personally orchestrating irregular entry.

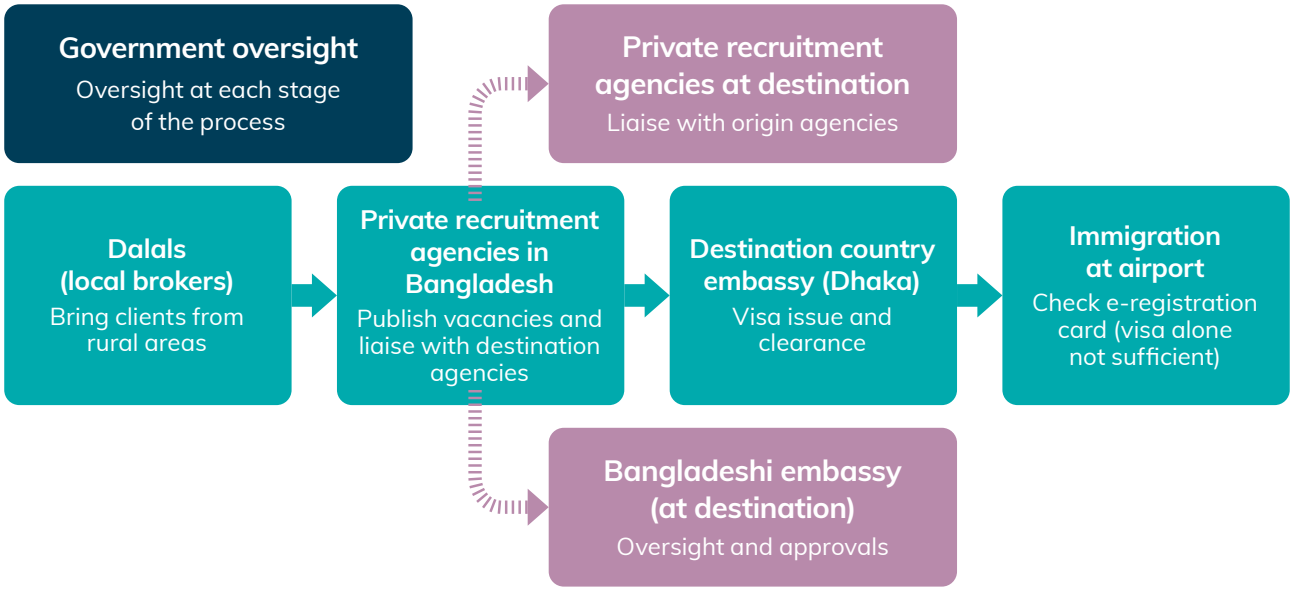
This distinction is essential to understanding how Bangladeshi migration to Libya and Europe functions. The route is characterised by layered facilitation and shifting operational roles, in which actors move fluidly between licit and illicit activities depending on opportunity, demand, and control at different points along the journey.

Among the nationalities using the Central Mediterranean Route, Bangladeshis have one of the most organised and structured migration systems to and through Libya, comparable only to the Eritreans. Bangladeshi networks are well established in both eastern and western Libya, with particularly strong footholds in the east, where the hybrid system of semi-formal entry and irregular onward movement is concentrated.

6.1 Recruitment process in Bangladesh

Migration from Bangladesh to Libya operates through a hybrid system that combines both formal and informal elements. While the journey is ultimately irregular, it often begins within the framework of the formal labour migration system, using the same actors, procedures, and documentation that govern legal recruitment in Bangladesh. This overlap between licit and illicit channels makes it difficult to distinguish where formal recruitment ends and smuggling begins, and it explains why understanding the recruitment process in Bangladesh is essential to analysing irregular migration routes to Libya and beyond.

Figure 5. Formal recruitment system in Bangladesh

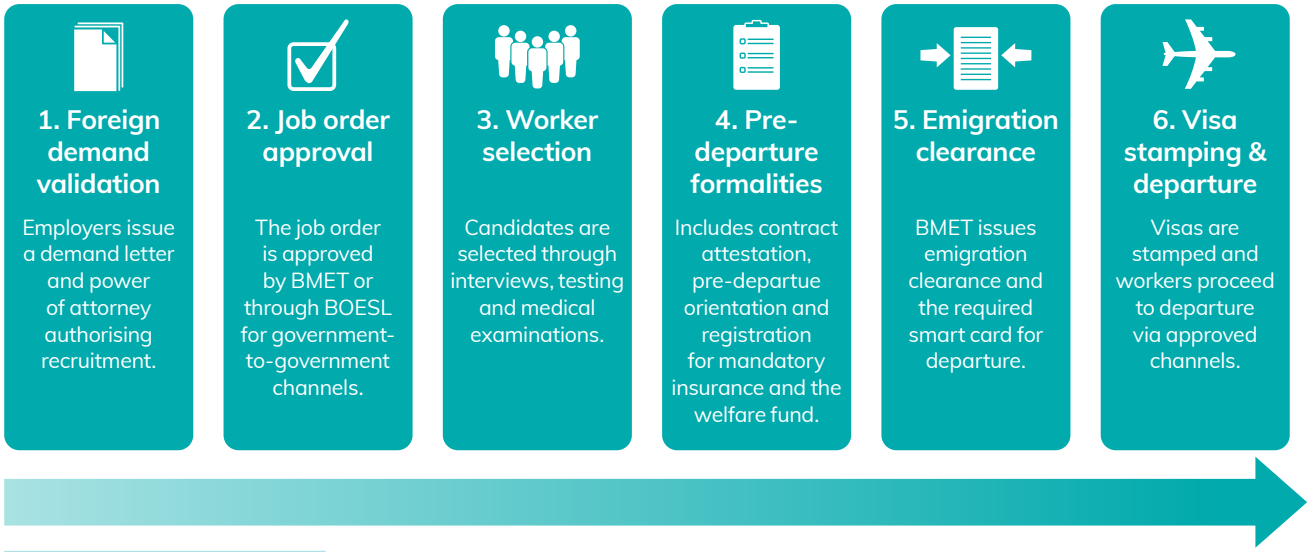


Under Bangladeshi law, all labour migration must be coordinated through licensed recruitment agencies. Recruitment agencies are the principal intermediaries linking Bangladeshi workers with overseas employers and play a pivotal role in the country's labour migration industry. Licensed by the Bureau of Manpower, Employment and Training (BMET) under the Overseas Employment and Migrants Act (2013), these agencies are authorised to secure foreign job orders, arrange contracts, and process emigration clearances. In practice, however, their operations often extend beyond formal oversight. Many rely on extensive networks of informal sub-agents (dalals) in rural areas who identify and mobilise prospective migrants, collect fees, and coordinate documentation. While this system enables nationwide recruitment reach, it also fuels information asymmetry, inflated costs, and opportunities for deception, especially where regulatory monitoring is weak. As a result, recruitment agencies occupy a dual position: essential conduits for overseas employment and key pressure points for exploitation within Bangladesh's migration economy.[7]

The recruitment industry falls under the jurisdiction of the Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment (MoEWOE), with BMET responsible for licensing, monitoring, and issuing the smart card required for departure.[8] Migrants must present this registration document at the airport alongside their visa, and a formal fee is charged for its issuance. However, unofficial payments to expedite or secure documentation are widely reported.

A standard overseas placement typically proceeds through several key steps, as presented below.

Figure 6. Process for standard overseas placement



7 RMMRU (2021) Sub-Agent Registration Model (English). Dhaka: RMMRU; IOM (2020) Mapping of labour migration recruitment practices in Bangladesh. Dhaka: IOM.

8 Bangladesh Overseas Employment and Services Limited (BOESL) for government to government channels

Despite this regulatory framework, recruitment remains a high-profit, low-investment enterprise. A BMET licence requires limited capital, yet offers access to a lucrative market. While some reputable agencies operate transparently, many are reported to collude with informal brokers or engage in illicit practices, including visa trading, which further inflates migration costs. According to key informant estimates, Bangladesh has roughly 2,270 licensed recruitment agencies, of which around 1,600 are active, although oversight remains inconsistent.

Civil society organisations and international agencies have long advocated for the formal recognition or registration of sub-agents to improve transparency and accountability within the recruitment chain. However, major recruitment agencies have resisted such reforms, as their business models depend on informal intermediaries to attract clients and distribute migration opportunities. These dynamics contribute to Bangladesh having the highest migration costs in South Asia, driving widespread indebtedness among migrants well before departure. This occurs not only on journeys to Libya and Italy but across key destinations such as Malaysia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE).[9]

This system lends itself to systemic manipulation and profit extraction. A typical example illustrates how this occurs: a sub-agent may receive ten approved employment visas for Malaysia but solicit payment from fifty potential migrants, collecting deposits from each before deciding who will travel. The sub-agent retains a share of these payments and transfers the remainder to the licensed recruitment agency. The agency, in turn, redistributes profits across a transnational chain of actors, including local brokers in the destination country, recruitment firms abroad, and occasionally officials in embassies or destination-country missions in Dhaka. Each layer introduces additional costs, expanding opportunities for rent-seeking, corruption, and exploitation. In this way, Bangladesh's formal migration infrastructure provides both the entry point and the veneer of legitimacy through which irregular and exploitative practices flourish.

6.2 Departing Bangladesh

The journey from Bangladesh marks the point where formal labour migration systems and irregular networks begin to overlap. Most Bangladeshi migrants who travel to Libya do so through pre-arranged "packages" that include air travel, visa processing, and entry clearance. Yet despite these formal appearances, these arrangements are typically embedded in informal brokerage chains that extend from village-level recruiters to transnational facilitators. The routes are therefore hybrid in nature, combining legal documentation and commercial air travel with the irregular practices that ultimately deliver migrants into Libya's informal economy.

Once a migrant decides to proceed, the dalal collects the passport and coordinates all subsequent steps, including visa acquisition and flight bookings. Migrants are instructed to appear at Dhaka airport on a set date, often joining a small group of others travelling the same route. These individuals usually do not know one another personally; they are linked through the same facilitation chain. This stage represents the transition point between Bangladesh's regulated migration system and the transnational smuggling networks that take over beyond national borders.

Facilitators employ a range of strategies to ensure smooth passage through Dhaka airport. In some cases, a network representative accompanies the group through immigration and security checks. Others reported travelling alone but being given a code number or instruction to present at migration control, which allowed them to pass without questioning.

In other cases, migrants pay extra to obtain a BMET "smart card", an official document required for regular labour migration. This allows them to pass through normal immigration channels without drawing attention, even when their destination is Libya. Nonetheless, airport authorities occasionally detain passengers en route to Libya for brief questioning, particularly when they suspect that travellers may intend to continue irregularly by boat to Italy. These interrogations are meant to distinguish regular labour migrants from those pursuing onward movement to Europe. Migrants typically respond that they are travelling to Libya for work, which is an explanation that aligns with the documentation they carry. They are therefore released and allowed to board their flights.

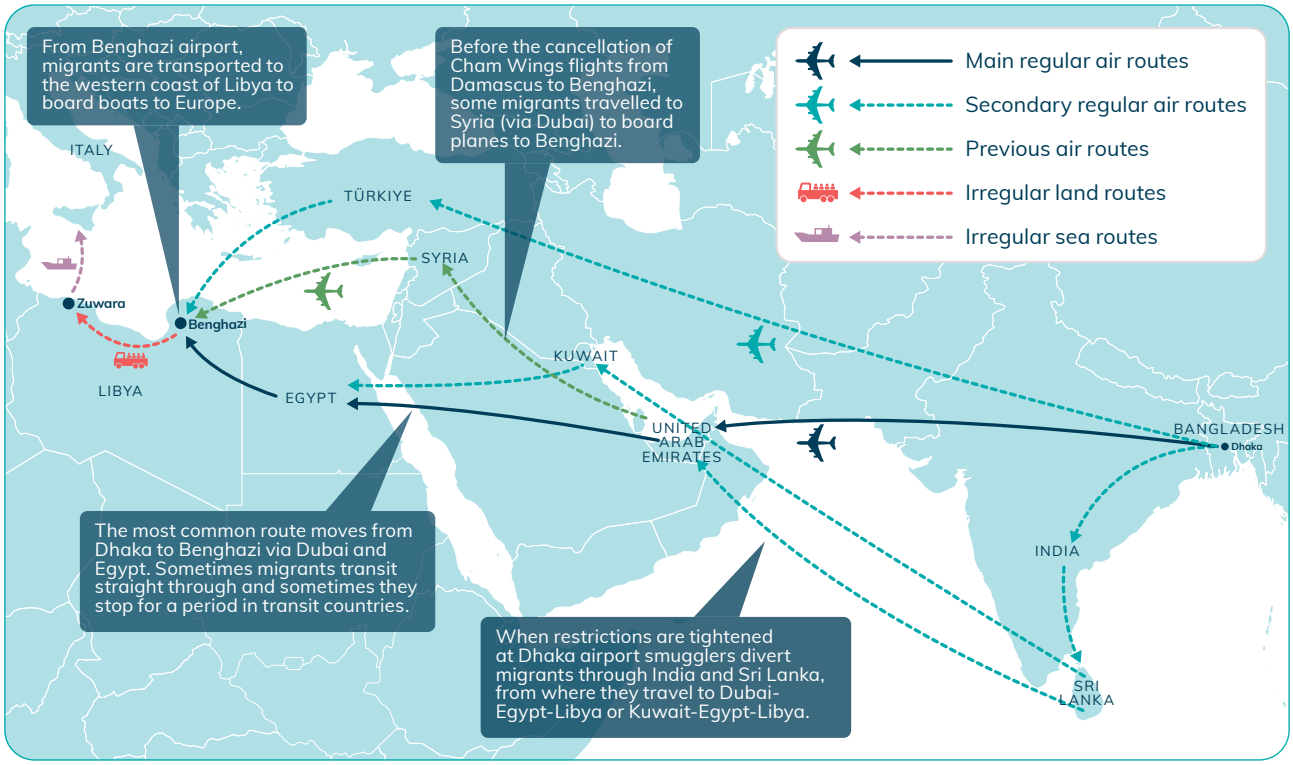
Many respondents described a recruitment process in which they never met the primary smuggler in person. Instead, communication took place entirely via Imo, a messaging platform widely used in Bangladesh. The smuggling chain is deliberately fragmented: one intermediary collects payments, another receives passports, and another delivers them once the visa is ready. This layered handover system protects the network by ensuring that no single actor manages the full operation, maintaining both secrecy and operational efficiency.

9 RMMRU (2021) Sub-Agent Registration Model (English). Dhaka;

6.3 Transit countries

Bangladeshi migration routes to Libya follow several overlapping patterns that reflect the adaptability of smuggling systems to shifting controls. The Gulf–North Africa route is the most common, typically following the path Bangladesh–Dubai–Egypt–Benghazi, though variations through India and Sri Lanka are used when restrictions tighten at Dhaka airport. This variation moves migrants through Bangladesh - India - Sri Lanka - Dubai - Egypt – Benghazi. A Gulf variation replaces Dubai with alternative hubs such as Kuwait, maintaining the same modular structure of recruitment, transit, and handover. A smaller share of movements occur through the Turkey route, either directly from Bangladesh to Turkey to Libya or with an additional Dubai stop before Turkey. This path is shorter but considered riskier due to stricter border surveillance. Finally, a Levant route—Bangladesh–Dubai–Syria–Benghazi—was occasionally reported but has seen limited use in recent years, largely following the suspension of Cham Wings flights in 2023. These routes are presented in the map.

Map 1. Routes from Bangladesh to Libya and Italy



6.3.1 Dubai as a transit hub

Among the identified routes, the Bangladesh–Dubai–Egypt–Benghazi corridor emerged as the most common. Migrants typically fly from Dhaka to Dubai before continuing either directly to Benghazi or onward via Egypt. Yet the duration of the stop in Dubai varies widely. Some migrants report moving through the airport within hours, escorted by a facilitator directly onto the connecting flight. Others are instructed to remain in Dubai for days or even weeks before continuing. This variation illustrates the uneven and adaptive nature of the facilitation system. While the exact reasons differ across cases, migrant testimonies indicate that the pace of transit often depends on how prepared the onward travel arrangements are when the journey begins.

In most cases, these differences stem from logistical, bureaucratic, and network-related factors. Migrants who move swiftly through Dubai are likely to have their Libyan entry permissions or sponsor arrangements finalised before departure from Bangladesh. Those who are held in transit, by contrast, are often waiting for pending visas, security clearances, or flight coordination managed by facilitators in Dubai or Cairo. Stopovers therefore act as buffer zones, giving facilitators time to finalise paperwork, confirm payments, and synchronise travel schedules. The decision to route migrants through Dubai, rather than directly to Egypt, may also reflect pragmatic considerations: UAE transit visas are easy to obtain, and Dubai hosts a well-established Bangladeshi brokerage network that allows facilitators to manage timing and logistics discreetly.

This system is sustained by a chain of semi-independent facilitators operating across legs of the journey: origin recruiters in Bangladesh, transit facilitators based in Dubai, and arrival facilitators in Libya. These actors are linked through informal communication, hawala or other payment mechanisms, and client handovers. Each controls a discrete phase but depends on the others for timing and documentation. Stopovers therefore serve a practical function within this chain, allowing handover between networks, verification of payments, and consolidation of groups before the next departure.

On arrival in Dubai, migrants are typically met by transit facilitators based in the UAE. They arev often Bangladeshi nationals embedded in the local brokerage scene. These facilitators escort migrants to holding locations, typically rented apartments or villas, where others are already waiting for onward travel. These sites bring together people recruited by different dalāls in Bangladesh but channelled into a single Dubai-based transit network that maintains direct links with facilitators in Libya. Some migrants reported being given USD 500 in cash before departure, with instructions to hand it to the facilitator in Dubai—an informal mechanism for cross-border payment confirmation within the same network.

Migrants generally remain in these locations until the next leg of their journey is confirmed. Dubai-based brokers coordinate with their counterparts in Bangladesh and Libya to align group sizes, flight schedules, and document readiness. Departures usually occur in small groups, not necessarily composed of people who began their journeys together, reflecting how Dubai functions as a consolidation hub within a broader facilitation economy.

In this way, Dubai operates as more than a transit point. It is a logistical and financial hinge connecting the recruitment infrastructure in Bangladesh with the smuggling economy that moves people into Libya. Whether migrants transit quickly or remain for weeks depends less on personal choice than on the operational dynamics of this decentralised network, where bureaucratic timing, financial flows, and inter-network coordination determine the rhythm of movement.

6.3.2 Alternative transit through India and Sri Lanka

An alternative pathway identified in this study follows the Bangladesh–India–Sri Lanka–Libya sequence, usually extending through Dubai, Kuwait, or Egypt before reaching Benghazi. This route tends to emerge when restrictions tighten at Dhaka airport or when Bangladeshi authorities increase scrutiny of passengers suspected of travelling irregularly to Libya. In such moments, smugglers reroute migrants overland to India, where entry requirements have traditionally been easier to navigate. Until recently, tourist visas for India were simple to obtain and did not require formal registration, allowing recruiters to move clients discreetly across the border.

Upon arrival in India, migrants typically remain for several days while facilitators arrange Sri Lankan tourist visas. Sri Lanka then serves as a temporary staging ground, where migrants stay in guesthouses or rented rooms for a few days to several weeks, awaiting the finalisation of their Libyan entry visa. Once the documentation is secured, the onward journey proceeds by air into Libya—most commonly via Dubai and Egypt, or in some cases, Kuwait and Egypt. Testimonies indicate that stopovers in Sri Lanka are primarily logistical: they allow facilitators to synchronise visa issuance and flight bookings while avoiding detection by Bangladeshi or Indian authorities.

The growing use of this route reflects the adaptability of smuggling networks to policy shifts at origin. However, informants noted that following the political transition in Bangladesh in 2024, visa procedures in India have tightened and surveillance of Bangladeshi travellers has increased, reducing the accessibility of this channel. Consequently, the India–Sri Lanka route now functions as a secondary pathway, activated primarily when direct departures from Dhaka become too risky or costly.

6.3.3 Transit through Syria

A smaller number of migrants reported travelling via the Bangladesh–Dubai–Syria–Benghazi route. This pathway relied on Cham Wings Airlines, which operated regular commercial flights from Damascus to Benghazi until 2023. In these cases, migrants described being met upon arrival in Damascus by a Syrian facilitator, who handed them their boarding passes and escorted them through the airport directly to the connecting gate. The same individual reportedly boarded the Cham Wings flight with the migrants and accompanied them through immigration upon arrival in Benghazi.

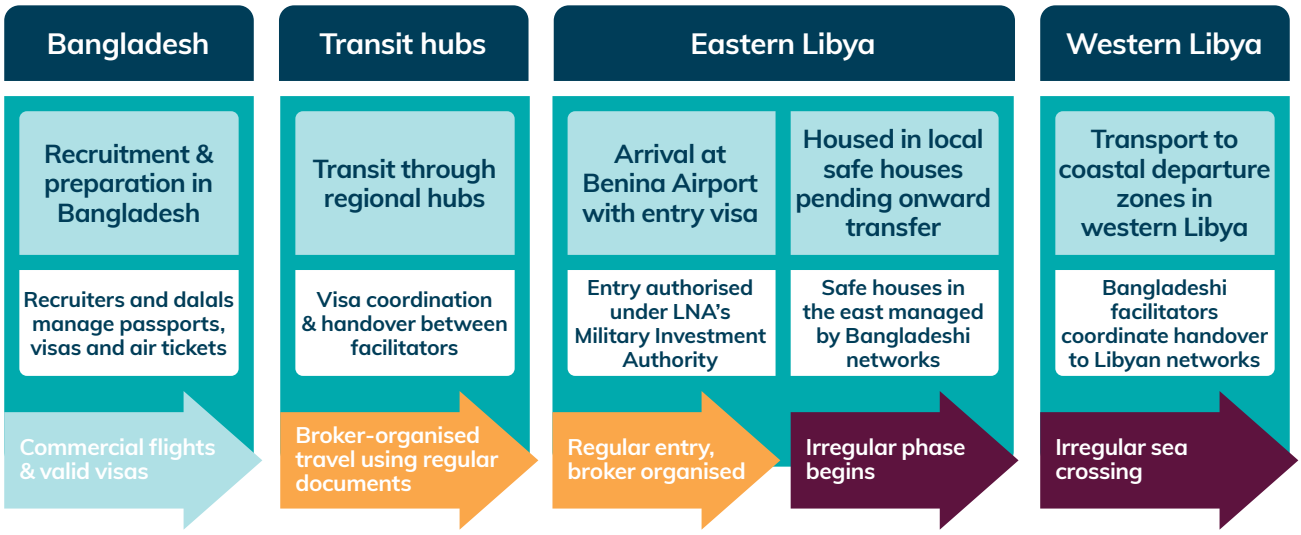
This arrangement suggests a high level of coordination between Bangladeshi and Syrian facilitators, allowing migrants to move through both airports with minimal scrutiny during the final stage of their journey. Such direct accompaniment also reflects the controlled and transactional nature of air-based facilitation, where payments, documents, and group management are handled with precision to avoid detection. The suspension of Cham Wings flights in 2023 effectively closed this corridor, further consolidating the dominance of Dubai- and Egypt-based routes into eastern Libya. Section 4.2 below describes the history of Cham Wings.

6.4 Smuggling through Eastern Libya

The emergence of an organised migration corridor through eastern Libya has reshaped movement along the Central Mediterranean route since 2020, beginning with the LNA's introduction of a new entry-visa system and evolving into a politically leveraged, commercially operated pathway distinct from the dynamics in western Libya. Syrians were the first to make this system viable, travelling via Cham Wings Airlines under a broader alignment between Haftar and the Assad regime, before Bangladeshi migrants increasingly came to dominate the route from late 2021. By 2023, eastern Libya had become a high-throughput entry point feeding directly into rising arrivals in Italy, even as sanctions on Cham Wings and selective crackdowns prompted networks to adapt—shifting some operations toward departures from Crete and, later, transporting migrants westward to Zuwara. Together, these developments illustrate how political incentives, commercial interests, and smuggling networks have converged to create a flexible, rapidly evolving system that now plays a central role in shaping migration flows from Libya to Italy.

6.4.1 The Eastern Libya migration system

Figure 7. The eastern Libya migration system



In 2020 after the war in Tripoli, the LNA faced financial crisis, and it is believed that this was the motivation in issuing the new entry visas, which are priced at 500 LYD (approx. USD $90). The eastern migration system is also perceived to be part of a broader political strategy by Field Marshal Khalifa Haftar, the commander of the LNA, to leverage migration as a bargaining tool in his relations with the European Union and Italy. In 2023, Haftar was invited by Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni to Palazzo Chigi for discussions on migration cooperation.[10] Maltese officials have also acknowledged coordination with Haftar's forces.[11] It is important to note that this entry regime is a formalised, state-issued system, distinct from smuggling operations, which are discussed separately in the next section.

10 https://www.ispionline.it/en/publication/charting-risky-waters-italy-and-khalifa-haftars-role-in-libya-134318?utm_source=chatgpt.com
11 https://www.spiegel.de/international/europe/more-like-kidnapping-a-brutal-libyan-militia-helps-europe-keep-migrants-at-bay-a-0c68d2b5-37bd-4267-b98c-8279a059e2bc

Although migrants entering eastern Libya do so legally, they are not recognised by the authorities in western Libya, who classify them as irregular if they cross into areas under Tripoli's control. This has effectively created two separate migration systems within Libya, each managed by competing authorities.

This bifurcated system is also visible in permit-status trends over time. As shown in Figure 7 below, Benghazi has experienced a steady and sustained increase in the number of migrants reporting a valid permit since mid-2020 (IOM DTM data), with a marked acceleration from mid-2021 onwards. By late 2024, migrants holding permits outnumbered those without, indicating a gradual consolidation of a semi-formalised entry and residence regime under LNA control.

This pattern is not mirrored elsewhere in the country. Figure 8, which presents the same indicators at the national level, shows that migrants without permits continue to overwhelmingly outnumber those with regular status across Libya as a whole. The divergence between Benghazi and the national trend underscores the eastern region's role as an exception rather than a precursor of broader regularisation. Rather than signalling a nationwide shift, the data point to a geographically contained system in which regular entry is selectively enabled in the east, while irregularity remains the dominant condition elsewhere.

Figure 8. Reported status of migrants in Benghazi[12]

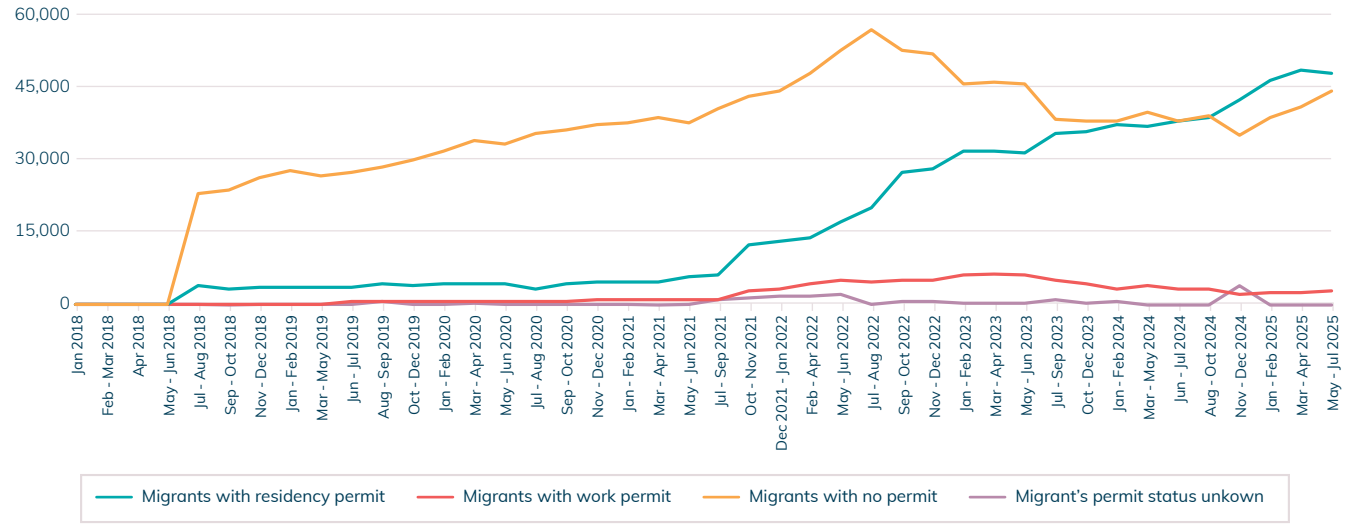
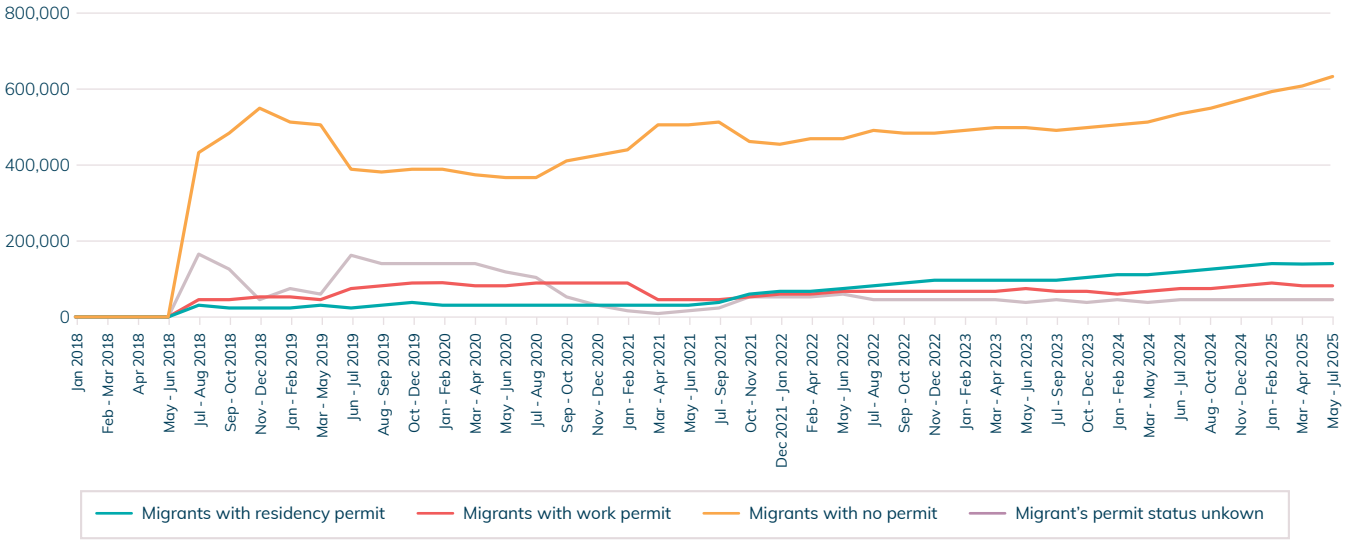


Figure 9. Reported status of migrants, nationwide[13]



12 Data source: IOM DTM
13 Data source: IOM DTM

6.4.2 The Role of Cham Wings Airlines and the Movement of Syrians

Through this system, travel agencies in countries of origin began selling all-inclusive "migration packages" covering the entire route: airfare, entry clearance for eastern Libya, airport pick-up, accommodation, overland transport to the coast, and the final boat journey to Italy. Initially, the corridor was used mainly by Syrians, whose arrival made the eastern system financially viable. It was facilitated by Cham Wings Airlines, a private Syrian carrier that started operating direct flights from Damascus, and occasionally via Beirut, to Benina International Airport in Benghazi. In 2020, at least 33 flights were documented on this route, establishing a structured air corridor between Syria and eastern Libya.[14]

Cham Wings reportedly suspended flights to Benghazi in 2023, after its owner, Issam Shammout, came under intensified international scrutiny. Cham Wings has been sanctioned multiple times; by the United States in 2016 and again by the European Union on 22 January 2024. The 2024 EU legal act explicitly identified a Syria–eastern Libya network operating through Cham Wings flights for illicit transactions, including narcotics trafficking and the movement of Syrian militias into Libya to support Haftar. The EU regulation states that Cham Wings *"uses its flights to engage in the transfer of Syrian mercenaries, arms trade, narcotics trafficking, and money-laundering, which supports the activities of the Syrian regime."*[15]

Since 2020, Khalifa Haftar's forces in eastern Libya and Bashar al-Assad's regime in Syria have maintained a pragmatic alliance grounded in shared opposition to Turkey and reinforced by Russian and UAE backing. The partnership included military training for Haftar's pilots in Syria, intelligence coordination, and logistical cooperation. Russia and Assad facilitated the movement of Syrian militias to Libya in support of Haftar (transported by Cham Wings), reflecting a wider geopolitical alignment. While the relationship provided Assad with financial and diplomatic lifelines and strengthened Haftar's international links, the fall of Assad in 2024 reportedly disrupted smuggling networks between Syria and Libya.[16]

6.4.3 The entrance of Bangladeshis

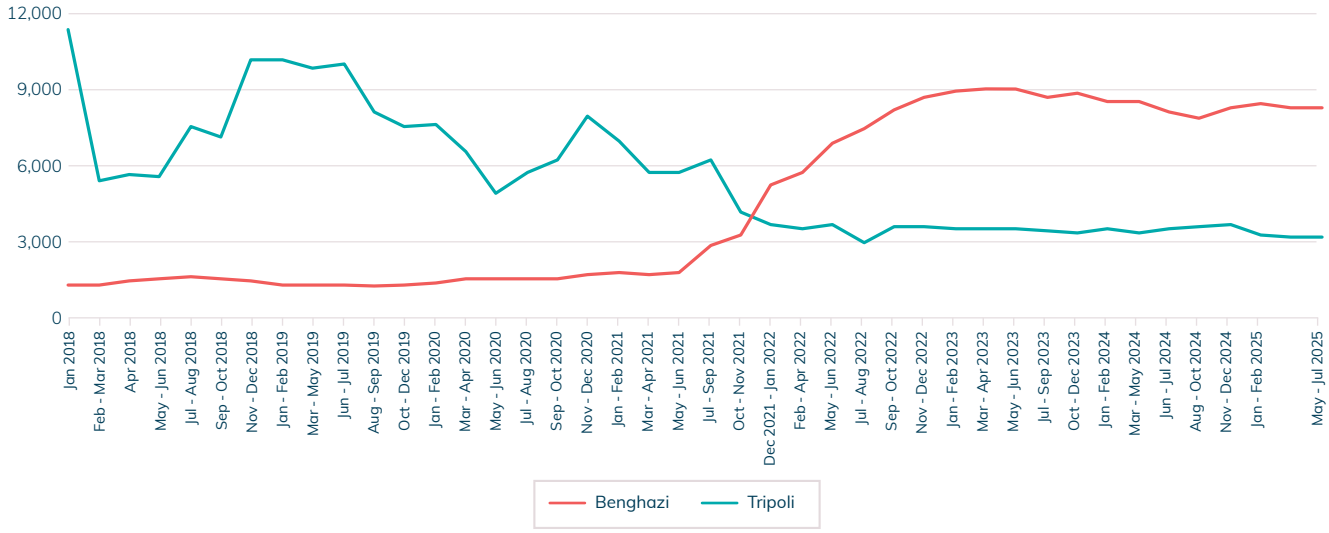
By the end of 2021, Bangladeshis started arriving in Benghazi, initially on Cham Wings flights from Syria (after flying from Bangladesh to Syria and then onward to Libya). This shift is clearly visible in the data, which shows arrivals of Bangladeshis through Benghazi beginning a sustained upward trajectory from late 2021, eventually overtaking Tripoli as the primary entry point (see Figure 10).

14 Letter dated 8 March 2021 from the Panel of Experts on Libya established pursuant to resolution 1973 (2011) addressed to the President of the Security Council

15 European Union. (2024) Council Implementing Regulation (EU) 2024/362 of 22 January 2024 implementing Article 29(1) of Regulation (EU) No 36/2012 concerning restrictive measures in view of the situation in Syria. Official Journal of the European Union, L 57, pp. 92-94; Reuters. (2024, 22 January) EU sanctions al-Assad's supporters and five companies. Reuters; U.S. Department of the Treasury. (2024, 26 March) Treasury sanctions financial facilitators and illicit drug traffickers supporting Syria's Assad regime. Press Release; Omran Studies. (2023, 7 September) How a drug kingpin is running flights from Damascus to the rest of the world.Omran Studies; El País (English Edition). (2024, 16 February) From Damascus to Benghazi: Migrant trafficking reaches tourism fairs; Syrian Observer. (2024, 24 January) Syrian companies under gaze of European sanctions: what is known about them.

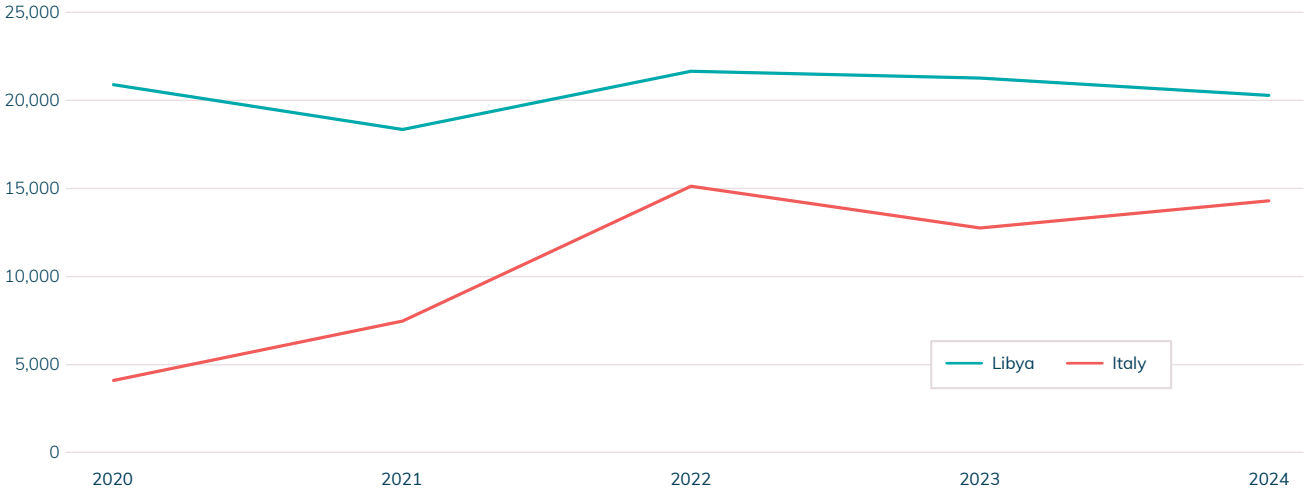
16 Africa Intelligence. (2024, 11 December) What Assad's fall means for Libya's Haftar clan. Africa Intelligence; Libya Observer. (2024, 12 December) Haftar was shocked by sudden fall of Assad regime. Libya Observer; Reuters. (2020, 7 May) U.S. says Russia is working with Syria's Assad to move militia to Libya. Reuters; European Council on Foreign Relations (ECFR). (2020) Assad's outreach to Haftar: The return of Damascus to North Africa. ECFR; The New Arab. (2020, 2 March) Assad and Libya's Haftar announce alliance to combat Turkish aggression. The New Arab.

Figure 10. Presence of Bangladeshi nationals in Benghazi and Tripoli (DTM data)



Once Bangladeshis started to arrive in Benghazi, arrivals in Italy from eastern Libya started to climb. By the end of 2023, when Cham Wings flights were suspended, Bangladeshis were reaching Benghazi through routes that bypassed Syria entirely. This means that while the Syrians made the Eastern system viable, the Bangladeshis had taken it over by the end of 2023. Figure 11 shows us that Bangladeshi arrivals in Italy increased sharply between 2020 and 2025, while the overall Bangladeshi population in Libya remained largely stable: a pattern that aligns with the emergence of a faster, higher-throughput corridor through eastern Libya."

Figure 11. Bangladeshi arrivals in Italy and Libya[17]



6.4.4 Current trends

Late 2023 also saw Italy and Malta entering direct talks with Haftar around migration management and the curbing of irregular departures from Eastern Libya. This led to selective crackdowns on smaller smuggling operations in eastern Libya. Enforcement measures during this period included the destruction of some boats, while other departures continued and adapted by re-routing toward Crete. This pattern of selective enforcement indicates that larger operations, often insulated by political or financial interests, remained active.

17 Data source: DTM

As a result, Bangladeshi networks started to transport migrants from Benghazi to Zuwara, on the western coast, so that migrants could board boats to Italy instead of Crete. DTM and other monitoring systems recorded a notable surge in departures from Zuwara in October 2023, coinciding with this east-to-west movement.

6.5 Movements from Eastern Libya to Western Libya

The movement of migrants from eastern to western Libya follows a structured but highly fragmented system shaped by local sponsorship arrangements at Benghazi airport, a chain of regionally controlled smuggling hubs, and negotiated passage across territory held by different armed actors. While eastern authorities impose registration and health screening procedures, this framework dissolves once migrants cross into western Libya, where control shifts to long-established coastal groups. The final handover into the so-called "game houses" marks both the end of the east–west journey and the beginning of a far more unpredictable and often violent phase dominated entirely by western Libyan smugglers.

6.5.1 Arrival into Eastern Libya

When migrants arrive at Benina International Airport in Benghazi, they are required to have a local sponsor from the city to enter. The sponsor system is an integral part of the process, and smugglers have established networks of local contacts who fulfil this role. Several migrants described being directed into a special queue for Bangladeshis, an arrangement that reflects how well established and institutionalised the Bangladeshi network has become through eastern Libya.

Upon exiting the airport, a car is typically waiting for each migrant. The driver is always reported to be Libyan, and carries a list of names and photographs of the individuals he is assigned to collect. Migrants consistently reported that multiple cars are lined up outside the airport, each designated for a different nationality. Every car corresponds to a different smuggling ring: even Bangladeshi migrants who travelled together from Dubai are separated into different vehicles at Benghazi airport, depending on which network facilitated their journey from Bangladesh.

The migrants are then transported to a first holding location, typically located in or near Benghazi, where they stay temporarily before being moved onward. These initial holding locations are usually segregated by nationality, with Bangladeshi migrants housed together. Once settled in the first holding location near Benghazi, arrangements are made for the migrants' onward movement from eastern to western Libya.

6.5.2 A network of regional hubs

Available evidence suggests that **Libya's smuggling economy is hub-based and locally embedded,** rather than controlled by coast-to-coast organisations. It functions through a chain of regional hubs across the south, east, and western coastal areas. These hubs are influenced by local power structures, including armed actors and commercial interests operating within conflict economies. Outsiders cannot simply move through or conduct operations without local partnerships. This structure means that actors from the east cannot directly manage western coastal points such as Zuwara or Zawiya; instead, they must negotiate, subcontract, or hand over migrants to the established local networks that dominate these areas.

6.5.3 Routes of travel from east to west

After leaving Benghazi, convoys travel westward, either along the coastal highway from Benghazi to Ajdabiya, then Sirte, Misrata, Tripoli, eventually arriving in Zuwara. Since the outbreak of conflict in Sudan, the Ajdabiya corridor has become heavily congested and more tightly controlled due to increased Sudanese displacement through eastern Libya and LNA security measures in response.[18] As a result, eastern networks have increasingly shifted away from the Ajdabiya coastal route, preferring desert tracks through Shwerayif and the western mountain region. From there, they will move northwards toward the coast.

18 UN Panel of Experts on Libya (2023–2024)

As migrants travel westward from Benghazi, they encounter multiple checkpoints operated by a range of security actors. In some cases, vehicles and drivers were changed as migrants moved between areas of control; in other cases, accompaniment was reported. Overall, these accounts illustrate how transit through the corridor is shaped by fragmented authority and locally negotiated arrangements between smugglers and various other actors.

6.5.4 Registration and health controls under the LNA

In eastern Libya, migrants described a structured system of registration and medical screening overseen by the Libyan National Army (LNA). At checkpoints, they were required to undergo blood tests to screen for communicable diseases. Those who tested positive were deported, while those cleared were issued a security registration card and permitted to continue their journey. Migrants also reported that they were required to show this card at subsequent checkpoints along the route, suggesting a coordinated and standardised process across LNA-controlled territory.

This system represents a form of migration management established by the LNA, blending security oversight with rudimentary public health controls. It allows the eastern authorities to monitor and regulate movement through their territory while maintaining the appearance of order and control. However, once migrants cross west of Sirte into areas under the Government of National Unity (GNU), this registration ceases to hold validity. Beyond that point, movements occur entirely through informal channels, facilitated by smuggling networks and negotiated passage across multiple checkpoints to reach the western coast.

6.5.5 Cooperation, not expansion

Once migrants reach western Libya, they are taken to what they call the "game house"—the final holding site before departure for the coast. The term "*game*" is widely used among Bangladeshi migrants to describe the irregular boat crossing of the Mediterranean, and the "game house" is thus the place where the "game" begins. These sites are always managed by Libyan smugglers and accommodate mixed nationalities, marking a clear transition from the Bangladeshi-run holding locations in the east. This point represents the handover, where Bangladeshi networks relinquish control to the Libyan groups that dominate the coastal departure points.

The game house is consistently described by migrants as the most dangerous part of the journey. Up to this point, their Bangladeshi smugglers maintain some control and can offer limited protection. But from the moment they enter the game house, the Libyan smugglers take over—and are widely described as brutal and unpredictable. Whether a person passes through quickly or suffers prolonged abuse depends largely on chance. Some migrants reported being extorted in the game house, forced to pay additional sums despite assurances from their Bangladeshi facilitators that the entire journey had already been covered.

Bangladeshi intermediaries decide which Libyan smuggler, or game operator, to hand each migrant to, often based on the amount of money paid in Bangladesh. Migrants noted that their fate depends heavily on the honesty of the *dalal*: in some cases, those who paid less, or dealt with dishonest brokers, were never even given a chance to attempt the "game" at all.

6.6 Boat departures from the western coast

The majority of migrants in our sample departed from Zuwara, while a smaller number departed from Zawiya, and had travelled after October 2023. The data indicates that the choice of departure site is opportunistic rather than hierarchical, shaped by local political dynamics and security conditions rather than by a fixed coastal structure. In other words, traffic flows rotate between coastal nodes according to who enjoys short-term protection and who is being pressured at a given time.

Operationally, the final leg mirrors the hub-and-handover model described earlier. From second-stage holding sites around Tripolitania, mixed-nationality groups are moved after midnight in closed lorries to minimise detection and manage ransom risk. The coast-side interface is highly compressed: a military or militia figure often supervises embarkation; groups are rushed aboard with little sequencing; and crews include a handful of migrants pre-selected and briefed to steer, handle fuel, or troubleshoot engines. Vessels range from repurposed fishing boats to larger

wooden craft; loads of several hundred people are not unusual. The crossing to Lampedusa can be direct and fast, typically 24 to 36 hours in fair weather, but remains precarious. Mechanical failures and dehydration are common, and even the "smoothest" journeys involve severe physical risk rather than reduced danger.

Search-and-rescue and interception patterns further underscore these dynamics. Bangladeshis were among the most intercepted and returned nationalities between 2019 and 2022, with IOM Libya's Search and Rescue data recording 4,451 Bangladeshi interceptions in 2022, the highest of any nationality that year. In 2023, however, that figure fell sharply to 1,668—a 63 per cent decrease. This decline likely reflects the same selective enforcement described above: negotiated tolerance for certain operators, temporary shutdowns of others, and altered embarkation points that reduced patrol predictability. In short, fewer interceptions do not necessarily mean fewer departures; they may instead indicate a more coordinated and politically managed coastal economy.

For those intercepted, disembarkation rarely marks the end of the ordeal. As detailed in previous sections, Bangladeshi migrants report being rapidly handed from coastal forces to Bangladeshi intermediaries who demand additional payments for release or onward travel. This indicates that interception itself is embedded in the same economy of extraction as embarkation. Consular constraints further perpetuate this cycle. The Bangladeshi Embassy in Tripoli reports ongoing difficulty obtaining exit authorisations from Libyan authorities, leaving migrants who wish to return home effectively trapped. In 2023, the embassy sought to repatriate approximately 2,000 individuals but was unable to do so due to bureaucratic and logistical obstacles.

6.7 Arrivals into Western Libya

Some Bangladeshi migrants reported arriving directly into western Libya, travelling on flights from Dubai to Mitiga International Airport in Tripoli. Upon arrival, the process mirrored that of Benghazi: cars were lined up outside the terminal, each assigned to collect migrants of a specific nationality. As in the east, the drivers were Libyan and carried lists with names and photographs of those they were to receive, indicating the same level of coordination between airport authorities, local sponsors, and smuggling facilitators.

Like arrivals in the east, migrants entering through Tripoli were transported from the airport to a first holding location, typically accommodating only Bangladeshi nationals. These holding locations served as temporary holding sites while onward arrangements were organised. From there, the migrants were moved to a game house, the final holding point before departure, which was operated by Libyan smugglers and hosted mixed nationalities.

However, those arriving directly in western Libya often faced longer waiting times before departure compared to those who entered through the east. Some reported being held for several months (up to six) before being taken to the coast. This suggests that the Bangladeshi smuggling networks operating in eastern Libya may be more structured and organised.

6.8 The economics of smuggling

The economics of the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy route are shaped by a set of broadly understood price tiers that vary according to migrants' intentions, levels of risk, and the circumstances they face along the way. Standard packages, higher-tier options, and additional costs incurred inside Libya all reflect how payments adjust to the realities of the journey, while those who travelled to Libya for work follow a different cost structure altogether. Using these price patterns and verified arrival figures, this section also outlines a scenario-based approach to estimate the scale of the smuggling market, providing a grounded indication of its overall size without overstating precision.

6.9 Prices

The cost of travelling from Bangladesh to Italy follows a relatively standardised structure that is well understood in many migration-prone districts. For those who leave Bangladesh with the intention of reaching Italy, the journey is commonly priced at **USD 10,000**, divided into two instalments: an initial payment of USD 3,000 made in Bangladesh before departure, followed by USD 7,000 after the migrant arrives in Libya.

Alongside this standard package, some families opt for an "all-inclusive" version, typically costing around USD 14,000. Marketed as a higher-tier option, it is presented as covering the full journey as well as any contingencies that

may arise inside Libya. Its purpose is essentially reassurance: a premium product for households seeking a greater sense of security in an inherently uncertain environment.

However, even with these predefined packages, many migrants report that the overall cost of the journey increases once inside Libya. Additional payments, arising at various points and for a range of reasons (as described in the section on risks), often raise the total expenditure to **USD 15,000–17,000**. These higher amounts tend to correspond to journeys in which circumstances become more constrained and migrants have less control over their onward movement.

In contrast to Italy-bound travellers, migrants who go to Libya for the purpose of work encounter a different pricing model. Their entry, which takes place through semi-formal labour channels, is typically priced at **around USD 3,000** in total. This amount is usually split between a modest payment in Bangladesh (typically $500) before departure and the remainder upon arrival in Libya.

A separate cost structure applies to those who originally migrated to Libya for work but later decide to continue to Italy after their circumstances change. For these migrants, the price for the Libya–Italy leg alone is **approximately USD 5,000**. In these cases, the payment finances a late, and often urgent transition out of Libya rather than a pre-planned, long-distance journey from Bangladesh.

Taken together, these different pricing tiers illustrate how the economics of smuggling map onto the varied mobility trajectories captured in the profile typology. Each cost structure reflects not only the route taken but also the level of choice, constraint, and predictability that shapes the migrant's position along the continuum of risk.

6.10 Estimating the size of the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy smuggling market

To estimate the size of the smuggling economy that facilitates movement from Bangladesh to Italy via Libya, this report adopts a transparent, scenario-based method grounded in the evidence generated by the study. The objective is not to produce a precise valuation, which would be neither possible nor credible given the opacity of the system, but rather to establish a plausible order-of-magnitude estimate based on known flows and consistently reported price points.

The estimate draws on three main elements. First, it uses the official figure of 14,000 Bangladeshi arrivals to Italy from Libya in 2024, which provides a conservative proxy for the number of migrants who successfully completed the full payment cycle. This approach avoids overestimation by counting only those who reached Italy, while recognising that a proportion of those who paid for the journey did not arrive and therefore remain outside this lower-bound calculation.

Second, it incorporates the distinct price tiers documented through interviews: a standard package of USD 10,000 for the full journey from Bangladesh to Italy; a higher-tier "all-inclusive" option of USD 14,000; and significantly higher total expenditures of USD 16,000–17,000 among those who incurred additional costs inside Libya. These three tiers form the backbone of the model. Journeys undertaken by individuals who had originally travelled to Libya for work and later decided to continue to Italy, typically priced at USD 5,000 for the Libya–Italy leg alone, are treated as a separate category, acknowledging that they represent a minority within the overall Italy-bound flow.

Third, because there is no representative dataset that indicates how many migrants fall into each price category, the estimate relies on three scenario-based distributions: conservative, central, and upper-bound. The conservative scenario assumes that most migrants paid the lower end of the price spectrum; the central scenario reflects the balance suggested by interview data, in which a substantial proportion reported higher-than-expected payments; and the upper-bound scenario models a context in which cost escalation inside Libya was widespread. These scenarios provide a structured way to reflect uncertainty without imposing unwarranted precision.

Taken together, these elements allow for a credible, transparent estimate of the scale of the market. By anchoring the model in official arrival figures, consistently documented payment structures, and clearly stated scenario assumptions, the analysis provides a realistic lower-bound range for the revenue generated by smuggling networks facilitating movement from Bangladesh to Italy via Libya, without overstating the accuracy of figures that are, by nature, indicative.

To generate the figures presented in Table 1, the analysis first calculated an average price per migrant for each scenario based on the assumed distribution across the three price tiers. For example, in the conservative scenario, we arrive at USD 11,450 by adding (0.70 × 10,000) + (0.20 × 14,000) + (0.10 × 16,500). Each of the averages was then multiplied by the 14,000 Bangladeshi arrivals recorded in Italy in 2024 to estimate the corresponding annual revenue for that scenario. Because the calculation only includes those who successfully reached Italy, and does not account for individuals who paid but did not arrive, the resulting figures represent a lower-bound estimate of the size of the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy smuggling economy. **According to the model, the market size is estimated at USD 160-190 million.**

Table 1. Estimated market size of the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy smuggling economy in 2024

Scenario	Model	Average price	Market size
Conservative	70% pay 10,000 20% pay 14,000 10% pay 16,500	USD 11,450	USD 160 million
Central	50% pay 10,000 25% pay 14,000 25% pay 16,500	USD 12,625	USD 177 million
Upper-bound	30% pay 10,000 30% pay 14,000 40% pay 16,500	USD 13,800	USD 193 million

7. Trafficking and other risks

Bangladeshi migrants face extensive risks at every stage of their journey through Libya, from financial exploitation and kidnapping to systematic violence and psychological trauma. Their particular vulnerability stems from the unusually high level of family involvement in the migration process.

7.1 Journey risks

Bangladeshi migrants are considered "gold" within Libya's smuggling economy because they are seen as the most reliable source of payment. Behind every migrant is a family that remains deeply involved in the journey: negotiating with brokers in Bangladesh, arranging financing, coordinating payments during transit, and liaising with smugglers whenever problems arise. This sustained, communication and emotional investment make Bangladeshi families highly responsive to extortion demands. As a result, the migrants themselves become financial assets whose value lies in the almost certainty that their relatives will pay to protect them.

This perception has created an extortion economy in which every actor along the chain, Bangladeshi or Libyan, seeks to extract money from the same individual. Even after paying for a full "package" in Bangladesh, migrants face repeated demands once in Libya. At each new stage, facilitators find new justifications for payment: "security fees," "food costs," or "coastal clearance."

Figure 12. Drivers of migration through the stages of the journey

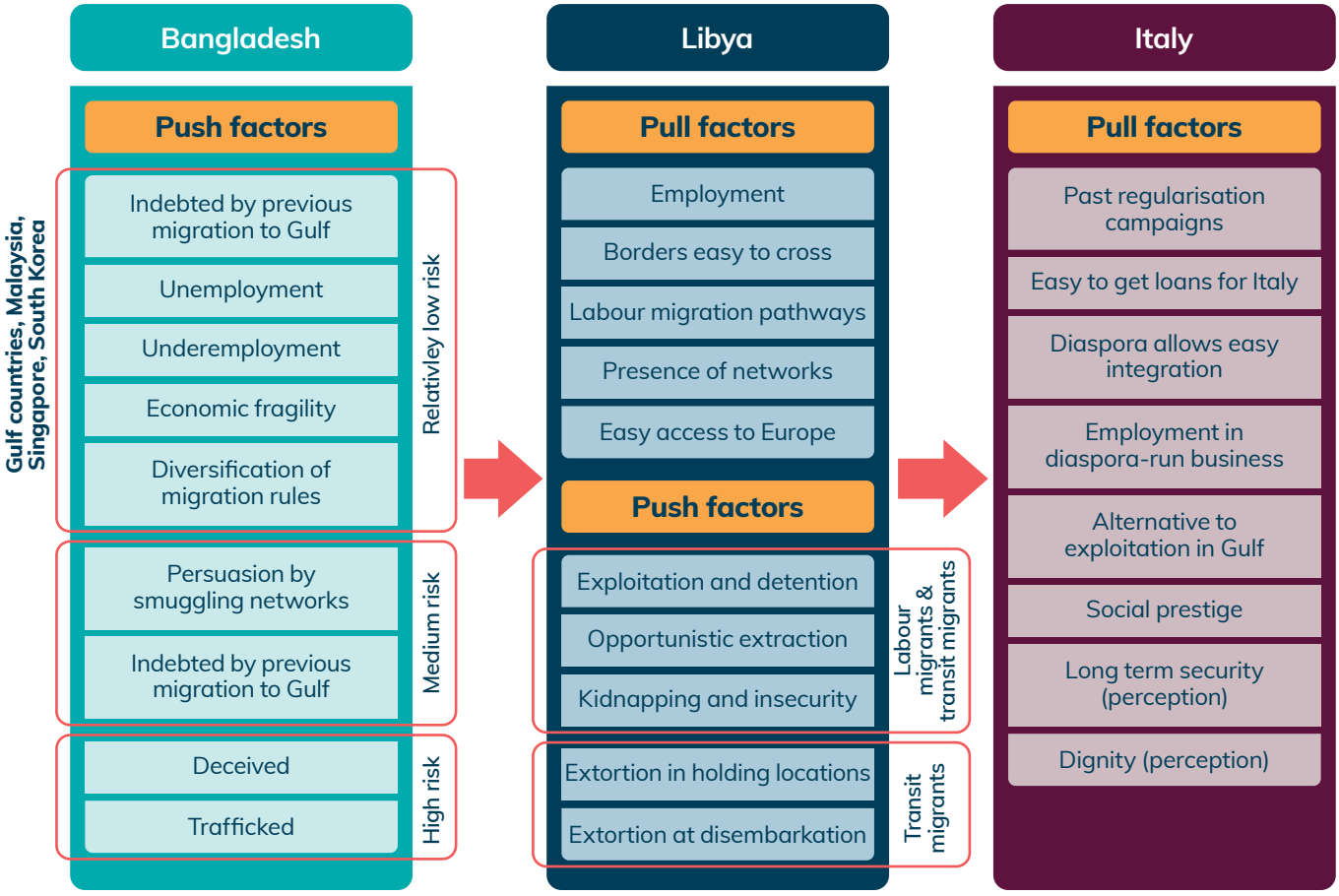


Figure 12 provides a conceptual overview of how structural push and pull factors across Bangladesh, Libya and Italy interact to shape the continuum of vulnerability in this corridor and shows how Libya functions simultaneously as a pull factor and a generator of exploitation-induced onward movement.

7.1.1 Opportunistic extraction along the route

At the most basic level, opportunism is routine. Drivers, guards, and escorts frequently ask migrants to surrender their cash or phones "for safekeeping," claiming that carrying valuables on the road is dangerous. Once handed over, these possessions are rarely returned. Such small-scale thefts are common because facilitators are often left alone with migrants for extended periods, creating moments of unchecked control.

7.1.2 Exploitation in holding locations

Facilitators managing holding locations also exploit delays in movement. When journeys stall, because of checkpoints, fighting, or changing agreements, conditions deteriorate in predictable stages. Food is first reduced, then withheld altogether, until migrants are told to pay more if they wish to resume eating or continue travelling. These practices are part of a broader business logic: each actor along the route expects to be compensated for additional time and risk. In the absence of formal agreements, coercion becomes the mechanism through which new payments are enforced.

7.1.3 Kidnapping and Insecurity

Beyond everyday opportunism, Bangladeshi migrants are also targeted by armed groups who understand their ransom value. Abductions occur during transport between holding locations or while travelling to and from workplaces. Migrants describe constant fear and restricted mobility, often confined indoors or moved only under escort. Those who do work outside leave before dawn, hidden inside goods trucks, and return by midday to avoid ambushes. Despite these precautions, kidnappings remain frequent. Some migrants reported armed men breaking into their accommodation at night to seize them for ransom.

7.1.4 Extortion in the game houses

At the final stage, in the game houses, which are the last holding sites before departure, Libyan smugglers routinely demand further payments, even from those who were told that their journey was fully paid in Bangladesh. When families hesitate, smugglers escalate pressure through violence and threats. Migrants recounted beatings, mock executions, and warnings of organ trafficking. Families in Bangladesh receive calls, photos, or videos showing their relatives in distress, accompanied by urgent instructions to send money through informal channels.

7.1.5 Orchestrated kidnappings

The same system that exposes migrants to kidnapping by Libyan groups also enables staged kidnappings orchestrated jointly by Bangladeshi and Libyan smugglers. These scenarios are designed to simulate abduction, forcing families to make new payments. In some cases, smugglers distinguish between "premium" and "normal" journeys. Those who pay for the "premium option" are promised protection. They are told that even if they are kidnapped or extorted, the smuggler will cover the costs and no further payment will be required. Those on the "normal option" are warned that if anything happens to them, they will have to pay for their own release. This distinction often sets the stage for manipulation: migrants who choose the normal option frequently experience kidnappings or detentions that appear to have been deliberately arranged to generate additional payments. In such cases, the original smuggler often appears at the end of a chain of extortion as the "saviour" and the migrants pay an additional sum to resume their journey.

7.1.6 Dynamics at disembarkation

Migrants in this study consistently reported that after being intercepted at sea by the Libyan Coast Guard, they were not taken into formal detention facilities, they were handed over to Bangladeshi networks operating along the western coast. These networks demanded additional payments for the migrants' release or onward travel, often contacting the migrants' families directly in Bangladesh. In most cases, the migrants' original smuggler also became involved, either by advising the families to pay or coordinating subsequent movements. It is not clear whether this

process reflects active collusion between different Bangladeshi groups or an informal procedure through which the Coast Guard routinely transfers custody of Bangladeshi migrants to these facilitators. What is evident, however, is that interception does not mark the end of the journey; it initiates a new round of financial negotiation between Bangladeshi intermediaries, Libyan actors, and the families at origin.

7.2 Trafficking dynamics

Patterns observed among Bangladeshi migrants in Libya reveal how smuggling and trafficking frequently overlap, forming part of the same continuum of exploitation. Across cases, the elements of trafficking are evident: recruitment through deception, the abuse of economic vulnerability, and exploitation through debt, coercion, or control of movement and identity documents. Whether presented as a repayment arrangement, temporary employment, or a means to cover ransom costs, the underlying mechanism is the same: migrants' labour and bodies are commodified to generate profit. Within Libya's fragmented economy, these practices have become a normalised extension of the smuggling system, where the distinction between facilitator and trafficker depends less on role and more on timing and intent.

7.2.1 Debt and bondage

The most common form of trafficking identified involves debt-based coercion. Migrants who cannot afford to pay for the journey upfront are told by facilitators that they can settle the cost after arriving in Europe. Believing they are entering into a credit arrangement, they effectively begin their journey already indebted. When they reach Libya, instead of continuing to Italy, they are informed that they must work to repay their travel debt. This work takes place under exploitative conditions: migrants have no freedom to choose their employer, wages are withheld, and the debt is inflated to ensure continued dependency. What begins as a smuggling arrangement transforms into labour bondage, with the debt serving as a mechanism of control.

7.2.2 Deceptive recruitment for work

Another pattern involves migrants who are told they are travelling to Italy through regular labour channels. These individuals enter Libya legally by air and are promised temporary work while waiting for their "next visa" to Italy. On arrival, their passports are confiscated under the pretext of processing paperwork, which is often the first sign of trafficking. They are put to work immediately, frequently in construction or service sectors, but receive no payment. Over time, they are informed that they have been "sold" to another employer or broker. In one reported case, seven migrants were collectively sold for USD 17,000; the new handler demanded USD 12,000 per person to secure their release. Such transactions demonstrate a market of human resale, where migrants are treated as tradable assets within Libya's informal labour economy.

7.2.3 Bonded labour during detention and kidnapping

A further form of exploitation occurs when migrants are kidnapped or detained for ransom. While families at home negotiate payments, the captives are forced to work, often in agriculture, construction, or manual labour, in order to cover their living costs or as punishment for delays in payment. This practice blurs the line between detention and labour exploitation, embedding trafficking practices within Libya's wider system of ransom-based extortion.

7.2.4 Broker-controlled labour system

For some migrants, the intention to travel to Libya is framed around finding work rather than reaching Europe. Smugglers in Bangladesh often assure them that employment will be arranged upon arrival, promising to "introduce them to someone who can help." However, this introduction rarely leads to direct or stable work. Instead, migrants enter a broker-controlled labour system that traps them in a cycle of debt and dependency. Even Bangladeshi migrants destined for Europe will sometime start looking for work in Libya when their onward travel becomes delayed and become introduced into this system.

Once in Libya, access to employment is mediated entirely by local brokers who control hiring, wages, and housing. Migrants must pay fees to obtain short-term jobs, and when these end, they are required to pay again to access new opportunities. In some cases, brokers withhold all earnings, claiming deductions for food, accommodation, or "service fees." When work is unavailable, migrants are obliged to remain in broker-managed housing, paying for subsistence even as they earn nothing. This arrangement strips them of financial autonomy and ties their survival to the broker's control.

Employment for Bangladeshi migrants in Libya is concentrated in low-wage, high-risk sectors that rely heavily on informal labour. Common areas of work include construction, housekeeping in hotels, bakeries, restaurants, cleaning services, domestic work, and carwashes. These sectors depend on irregular workers with little bargaining power and are therefore easily integrated into the broker system.

Although overt violence is not always used, the structure of this system constitutes coercion. Migrants have already invested heavily to reach Libya and cannot simply abandon the arrangement without losing everything they have paid. Their irregular status leaves them without legal protection or the ability to seek alternative work. The brokers exploit this vulnerability to maintain control over their labour and extract continuous payments.

This pattern reflects the core elements of trafficking for the purpose of labour exploitation as defined under the Palermo Protocol: recruitment through deception, movement across borders under false promises, and exploitation through abuse of vulnerability and control of labour. The deception at origin (promising employment that does not exist) coupled with economic coercion and the withholding of wages at destination, transforms what begins as smuggling into a trafficking relationship. The absence of physical restraint does not diminish the exploitative nature of the system; control is exercised through dependency, indebtedness, and the constant threat of destitution.

7.2.5 Other ways of securing employment in Libya

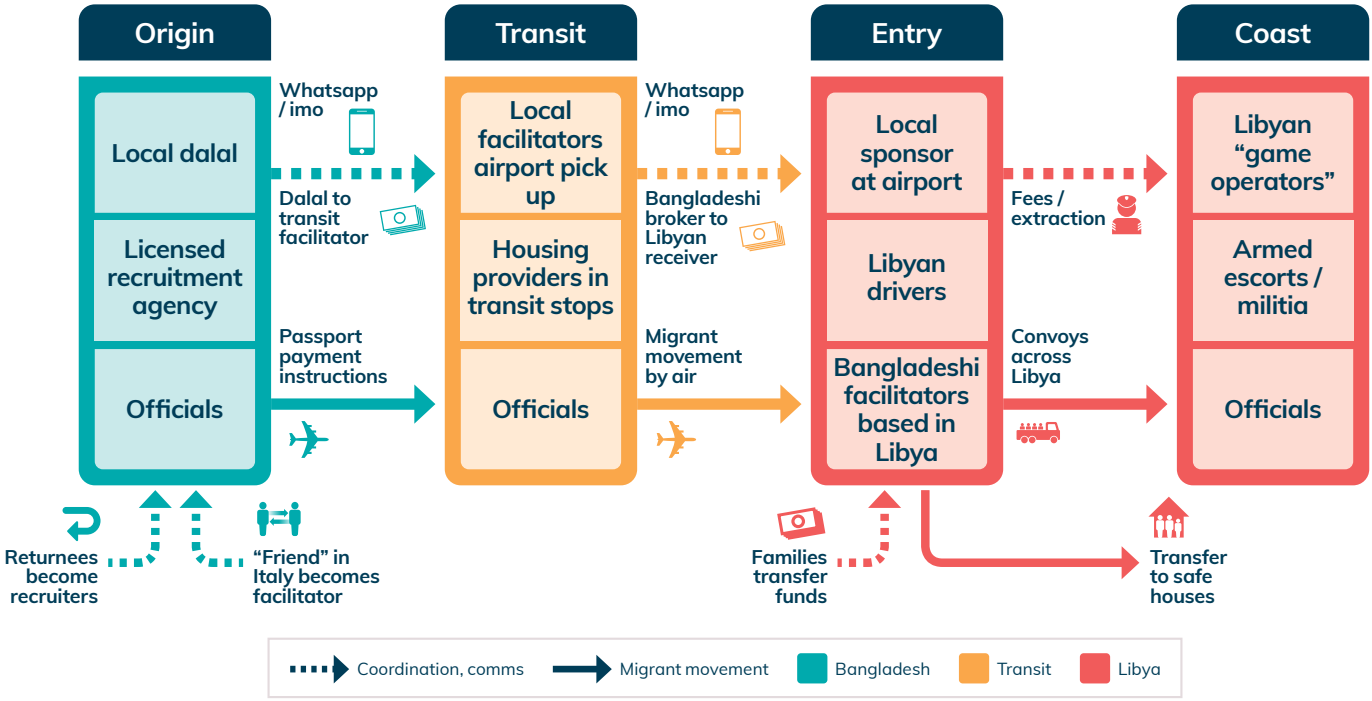
Some migrants access employment through existing Bangladeshi networks rather than brokers. In several cases, a relative already working in Libya organised the paperwork and arranged for the migrant to join them, using personal or employer connections to secure authorisation. Others reported that they arrived in Benghazi through the same facilitated travel system as smuggled migrants but were channelled into temporary work instead of transit. On arrival, they were accommodated in a holding location for around fifteen days while a work permit was arranged. Once the permit was obtained, they were transferred to their workplace and began receiving wages.

While these examples may reflect lawful or semi-formal employment, they nonetheless occur within the same brokerage system that enables exploitation. The intermediaries who arrange these opportunities often operate across both licit and illicit economies, facilitating documentation for some workers while withholding wages or confiscating passports for others. This overlap means that legality does not necessarily protect migrants from coercion; the mechanisms that enable legitimate work can easily be repurposed to sustain trafficking-like control.

8. Network structure and operational roles

The smuggling of Bangladeshi migrants via Libya is sustained by a multi-layered, trans-national network of operators: from origin brokers in Bangladesh through transit facilitators to Libyan smugglers controlling the final departure points. This section maps how each actor functions, how they coordinate with one another, and how payments, information and trust flow through the system.

Figure 13. Smuggling network structure and operational roles



8.1 A Multi-layered system of actors

Smuggling networks are best understood not as monolithic "cartels" but as flexible, modular structures in which different actors specialise in particular segments of the journey. In the Bangladesh-to-Libya route, this segmentation is clearly visible: recruitment and documentation in Bangladesh; transit via the UAE, Kuwait, Egypt or Syria; entry into Libya; movement across Libya; and finally maritime departure. Each segment is handled by actors with particular geographic, linguistic and institutional advantages.

8.1.1 Operators at origin: the recruitment chain in Bangladesh

At the origin end, the network is heavily pre-organised by Bangladeshi intermediaries:

- A *smuggler* **("dalal") in Bangladesh recruits the migrant**, negotiates the journey, collects the payment (either fully in advance or in part via instalments) and arranges onward documentation.
- Recruitment sometimes began through casual encounters in community spaces such as tea stalls or mosques, where brokers identified vulnerable young men and used **persuasive narratives** to draw them into the migration process.

- Respondents described being accompanied by a facilitator during parts of the departure process, including support through immigration and boarding. Such accounts point to the use of informal facilitation practices within airport environments and **the high level of coordination involved** in organising onward movement.

- **Migrants are incentivised:** some brokers offer discounts if the migrant brings friends with them, thereby increasing volume and reducing per-person cost.

- **Families in Bangladesh often transfer funds to Bangladeshi bank accounts of the broker;** sometimes payment occurs after arrival in Libya upon confirmation of safe arrival. This origin architecture underscores how the legal labour-migration apparatus is repurposed for irregular flows, leveraging Bangladesh's recruitment agencies, diaspora networks, and informal trust systems.

8.1.2 Transit facilitators and cross-border coordination

Between Bangladesh and Libya, transit facilitators play a crucial role. Examples include:

- **Flights through the UAE, Kuwait, Egypt, and Syria** where a local contact meets migrants at the gate, takes passports, and returns with boarding passes. In Syria, migrants reported that the facilitator even boarded the onward flight and travelled with them to Benghazi.

- In cases where migrants stopped in the UAE rather than transiting, **Emirati facilitators managed the Dubai segment independently**. Bangladeshi brokers subcontracted to these Emirati operators, who handled local logistics such as accommodation, visa processing, and airport clearance.

- Communication mechanisms were maintained throughout the journey via **WhatsApp or Imo,** allowing brokers to stay in contact with migrants, reinforce trust, and ensure compliance with payment and routing instructions.

This segment shows that medium-level facilitators coordinate handovers and transit flows to connect origin and destination segments.

8.1.3 The Libyan segment: embedded partnerships

Upon arrival in Libya, the network morphs into a hybrid structure embedded within local conflict-economies. The network needs someone in the east to obtain the entry clearance and receive the migrants in Benina International Airport and someone in Zuwara to organise departure:

- **Authorities in Benghazi airport require a sponsor** to receive those arriving on the entry clearance. Bangladeshi facilitators, either those that travelled with migrants or facilitators based in Libya handle the airport arrival, transport to initial holding locations, and liaison with origin brokers. These facilitators often speak Arabic and have close ties with Libyan actors.

- **Holding locations immediately after arrival are usually nationality-segregated** (Bangladeshi exclusively) and managed by Bangladeshi smugglers; but once migrants reach the "game house" stage, they are moved to Libyan-run facilities that host mixed nationalities and Libyan smugglers are in charge.

- **Libyan drivers dominate transportation between holding locations,** across checkpoints, and to the final coastal departure points. They often change cars along the route between east and west Libya, and in some cases secure police or military escorts.

- **Additional actors** include Sudanese facilitators working with Libyan groups (in the game house or at the coast), Pakistani facilitators working with Bangladeshi groups, and local militia or security forces who might be paid to allow passage.

- Migrants reported a uniformed military officer firing three gunshots at the coastal departure point just before boarding. While the exact purpose is not clear, the act could serve as a signal to coast-guards or militia to allow passage, a display of authority to ensure compliance, or a timing cue for embarking crews.

The cooperation between Bangladeshi and Libyan actors illustrates how, in fragmented conflict settings like Libya, smuggling networks rely on *negotiated access* rather than hierarchical control.

8.2 Financial and communication networks

Payment and communication channels are integral to system functioning:

- **Payment flows:** migrants pay their origin broker in Bangladesh (often before travel). After arrival in Libya, some pay additional amounts in the first holding location or at the game house. Migrants report being extorted by Libyan smugglers who demand more money despite the origin payment covering "the whole journey."

- **"Game operator" selection:** Bangladeshi brokers select a Libyan game-operator based on how much money the migrant has paid. Migrants emphasise that their success (or being abandoned entirely) often depends on this selection and the honesty of the Bangladeshi broker.

- **Trust and reputation:** Returning migrants often become brokers (dalals), signalling that the network reinvests its own clientele into its operator base.

- **Communication:** a *"friend" in Italy* often calls the migrant during the journey, presenting themselves as a trusted adviser but in reality acting on behalf of the smugglers. Their role is psychological: encouraging migrants to trust the network, comply with instructions, and make additional payments when requested. This function mirrors the pattern of returning migrants who later become brokers: both demonstrate how the network reinvests its own clientele into its operator base, turning former clients into facilitators who perpetuate the system.

These financial and communication practices reflect the business model of a modular smuggling "service", where each actor profits from their segment and the migrant's dependency on onward movement enhances leverage.

8.3 Coordination, risk, and trust

While the network thrives on decentralisation, several themes stand out:

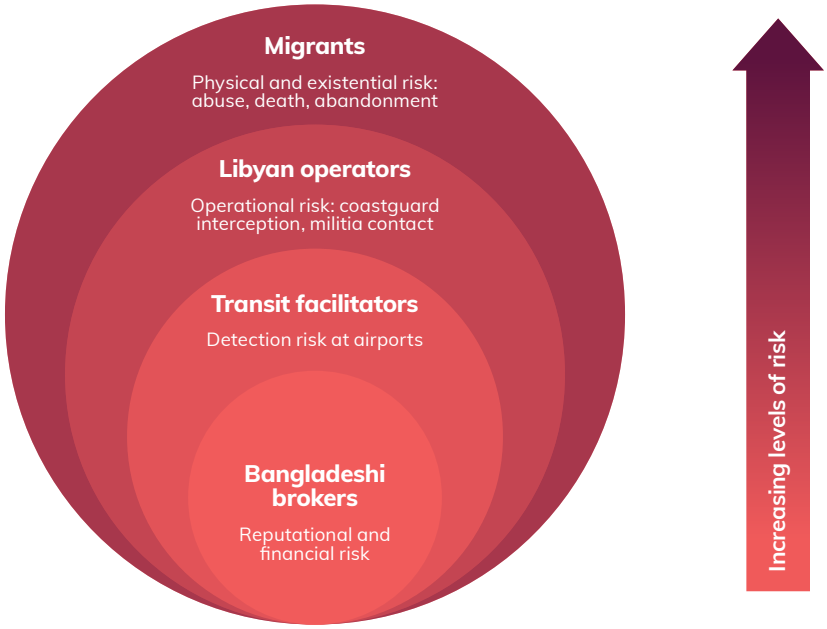
- **Coordination**: The segmentation requires coordination across countries and segments: for example, the Bangladeshi broker must liaise with the transit facilitator, who connects with the Libyan operator. Smugglers operate across origin, transit and destination nodes.

- **Risk distribution:** Each actor bears a different risk. Bangladeshi brokers risk reputation and client loss; transit facilitators risk detection at airports; Libyan operators risk interception by coastguards or rival militias. Migrants bear the highest risk of being abandoned, abuse, extortion or even death.

- **Trust:** Reputation matters. Migrants assess brokers based on peer networks. Brokers rely on performance (safe arrival, onward movement) to maintain clientele.

- **Adaptive business model:** As enforcement pressures shift, so do routes, actors and fees (for example, eastern to western movements through Libya). The network adapts, reinforcing the point that smugglers are highly responsive to border policy changes.

Figure 14. Risk distribution among actors on the migration route



This network of operators demonstrates how the Bangladeshi-Libyan smuggling corridor functions as a distributed criminal enterprise: segmented, flexible and embedded in multiple jurisdictions. Rather than a single organisation exerting control from origin to departure, the system relies on cooperation, negotiated hand-overs and trust-based business relationships. The segmentation enables resilience in a volatile context (such as Libya) and highlights how migration governance interventions focused solely on border-control or destination-coast interception must take into account the full chain of actors involved.

9. Intentions and onward movements

9.1 EU destinations and routes

Within Europe, Bangladeshi migration is highly concentrated rather than diffuse. Although Bangladeshi nationals are present across multiple EU+ countries, arrivals and asylum applications are overwhelmingly clustered in a small number of destinations, reflecting the structure of established routes, diaspora pull, and facilitation networks rather than broad destination choice. Italy dominates as the primary endpoint of movement, while a limited set of secondary destinations capture smaller, often derivative flows shaped by onward movement, labour-visa misuse, or secondary migration within the EU.

9.1.1 Asylum data

Table 2. Asylum applications by Bangladeshis across EU+

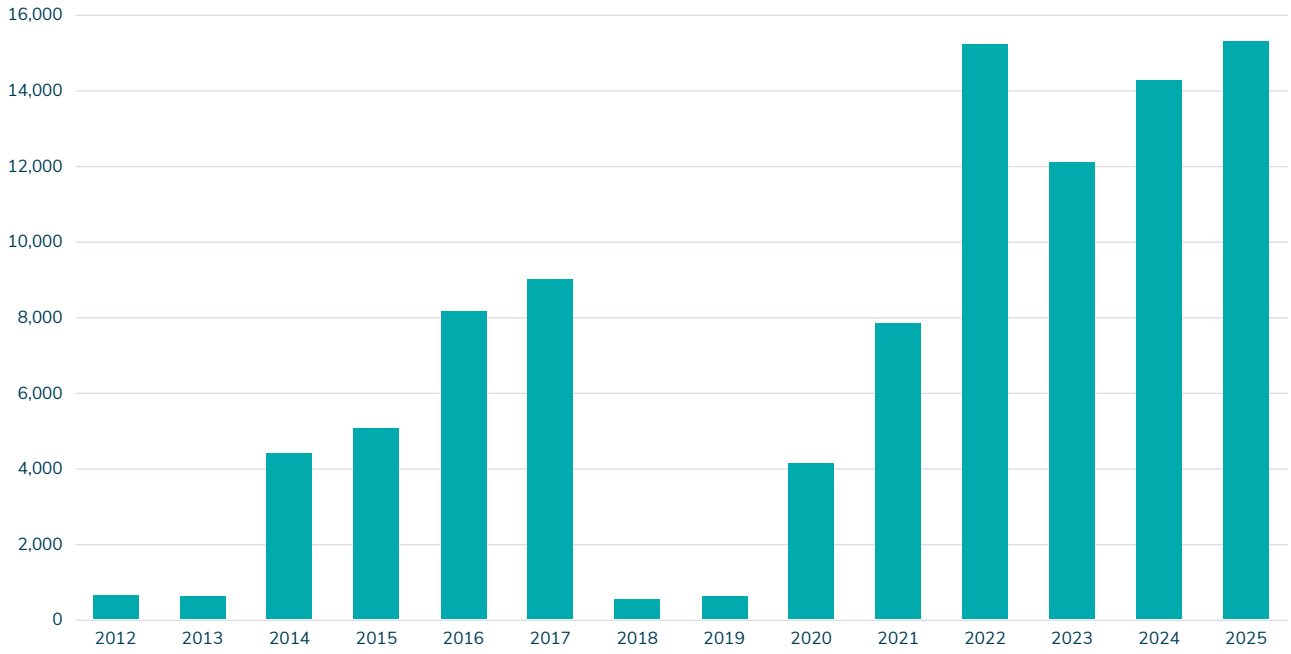
Country	Asylum applications
Italy By far the primary destination	• EUAA reporting shows Italy has received more than half of all Bangladeshi asylum applications in the EU+ since 2022. • In 2023 there were 23,448 applications (8%) from Bangladeshis.[19] • In 2024 this increased to 33,390 applications (21%) from Bangladeshis.[20] • In the first half of 2025, approx. 12,000 applications were lodged in Italy (three quarters of the total number lodged by Bangladeshis in Europe in that period).[21]
France The clear secondary destination	• EUAA notes France is the next largest recipient "at a distance," with **10,215** Bangladeshi applications in 2023 (a quarter of the total lodged in France).[22] • Decreased to 6,429 in 2024.[23]
Romania Smaller but notable	• EUAA-based tallies cited 2,822 Bangladeshi applications in 2023. • Often linked to labour-visa entry and onward movement.[24]
Austria Smaller but present	• 1,409 Bangladeshi applications in 2023.[25]
Greece, Ireland, Spain, Cyprus, Malta Lower volumes	• Indicative 2023 figures: Greece (~640), Ireland (~445), Spain (~380), Cyprus (~314), Malta (~118). These are mostly entry or lower-volume destination points relative to Italy/France.[26]
United Kingdom (UK) Non-EU and smaller	• The UK is outside the EU+ statistics. Bangladeshis appear among many small-boat nationalities, but UK data don't place Bangladesh among the top cohorts recently.[27]

19 https://euaa.europa.eu/news-events/bangladesh-latest-euaa-report-highlights-democratic-backslide-impacting-specific-profiles
20 https://euaa.europa.eu/publications/latest-asylum-trends-2024-annual-analysis
21 https://www.euaa.europa.eu/sites/default/files/publications/2025-09/2025.09_EUAA_Latest-Asylum-Trends_MYR2025_PUB-FINAL.pdf
22 https://euaa.europa.eu/news-events/bangladesh-latest-euaa-report-highlights-democratic-backslide-impacting-specific-profiles?
23 https://www.tbsnews.net/bangladesh/bangladeshi-asylum-applications-europe-hit-record-high-2024-96-rejected-1083366
24 https://www.tbsnews.net/bangladesh/record-number-bangladeshis-sought-asylum-europe-2023-801298
25 https://www.tbsnews.net/bangladesh/record-number-bangladeshis-sought-asylum-europe-2023-801298
26 https://www.tbsnews.net/bangladesh/record-number-bangladeshis-sought-asylum-europe-2023-801298
27 https://migrationobservatory.ox.ac.uk/resources/briefings/people-crossing-the-english-channel-in-small-boats/

When examining European destinations for Bangladeshi migrants, asylum application data can serve as a useful, though imperfect, proxy for intended destination. These figures do not capture all secondary movements within Europe, and not all Bangladeshis apply for asylum. Still, the scale of recorded applications is substantial and broadly mirrors the overall rise in Bangladeshi arrivals to Europe, therefore it provides an indication of intended destination in the absence of actual data points. According to data from the European Union Agency for Asylum (EUAA), between January 2022 and April 2024, Bangladeshi nationals lodged roughly 90,000 asylum applications across EU+ countries. Since August 2022, monthly applications have consistently exceeded 3,000, reaching a record high in March 2024. Italy remained the principal destination, receiving more than half of all Bangladeshi applications, followed, at a distance, by France, which accounted for over a quarter of the total.[28] Bangladeshi applicants have an EU+ recognition rate of around 4%.This is further delineated in Table 2.

9.1.2 Primary route: Central Mediterranean

Figure 15. Bangladeshi irregular arrivals in Italy from Libya[29]

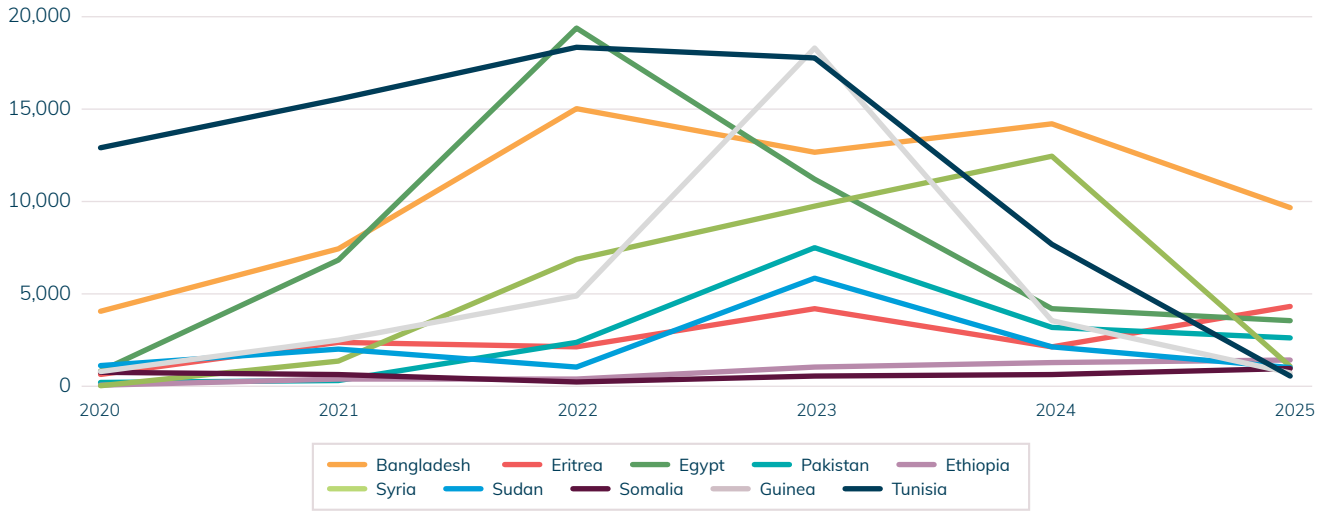


The Central Mediterranean remains the main corridor used by Bangladeshi migrants to reach Europe. According to IOM DTM data, around 90 per cent of all Bangladeshi arrivals in 2023 were registered in Italy, with nearly all having departed from Libya.[30] This is in line with the asylum data above. Figure 15 shows that arrivals of Bangladeshis on boats in Italy have risen sharply compared to pre-2020 levels and have remained consistently high since 2022. Bangladeshis are now among the largest nationalities arriving by sea in Italy.

In addition to the overall rise in Bangladeshi arrivals, the relative position of Bangladesh among other nationalities has also shifted. Figure 16 charts the top ten nationalities of arrivals in Italy over 2020-2025 with Bangladeshis highlighted in yellow. The figure shows that Bangladesh consistently ranked among the top three nationalities throughout the entire period and moved into first place in both 2024 and 2025. This confirms not only the scale of the flow but also Bangladesh's consolidation as one of the dominant nationalities arriving irregularly in Italy over recent years.

28 https://euaa.europa.eu/news-events/bangladesh-latest-euaa-report-highlights-democratic-backslide-impacting-specific-profiles
29 Data source: Italian MoI
30 IOM DTM (2024) Profile of Bangladeshi Migrants in Libya (15 July 2024)

Figure 16. Top 10 arrivals in Italy 2020-2025[31]



Across our sample, migrants consistently reported that Italy was their intended destination from the outset. Key informants noted that Bangladeshi migrants only aim for other European destinations, such as France or the United Kingdom, if they have relatives or friends already settled there. Otherwise, Italy is viewed as the final destination rather than a transit point. For those who do attempt to move onwards from Italy, the journey is typically organised through entirely separate smuggling networks that operate independently from the facilitators responsible for the Libya–Italy crossing. In some cases, however, migrants indicated that the initial smugglers provided referrals or contact details for these secondary facilitators within Italy, linking them to a new network for the next stage of their journey.

9.1.3 Secondary routes

A smaller but persistent flow of Bangladeshi migrants travels through the Eastern Mediterranean route, entering Europe via Türkiye and Greece before continuing along the Western Balkans corridor. The route typically begins in India, with migrants crossing on foot into Pakistan, here they join Pakistani migrants, continuing through Iran and Türkiye, and eventually moving through Greece, North Macedonia, Serbia, and Slovenia towards Italy or other EU Member States. Migrants on the Eastern Mediterranean route tend to demonstrate greater onward mobility within the EU, although Italy is still a key destination for this flow also.

Another emerging pathway involves entry through Romania, facilitated by a bilateral Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between Bangladesh and Romania allowing for legal labour migration. Some Bangladeshi migrants obtain Romanian work visas under the pretext of formal employment and then travel onwards to other EU Member States once in Europe. Several key informants reported that certain migrants paid intermediaries for employment and travel packages to Romania, only to discover upon arrival that no job existed. These individuals were left stranded and subsequently moved irregularly towards Italy, often with the assistance of secondary smugglers operating across Central Europe.

A number of European governments have expressed concern not about regular migration channels themselves, but about the way intermediaries in Bangladesh may distort or exploit them. In 2024, for example, Denmark announced tighter screening of student visas for Bangladeshi applicants following indications that some visa applications were being facilitated by brokers for purposes other than genuine study. This development underscores a broader governance challenge: vulnerabilities within origin-country recruitment ecosystems can affect visa categories that are otherwise legitimate.

31 2025 figures are until June 30.

9.2 Regular v irregular migration

The boundary between regular and irregular migration is increasingly blurred in the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy corridor. Many migrants begin with the intention of migrating legally, but limited knowledge, systemic barriers, and reliance on intermediaries expose them to manipulation within formal migration frameworks. Legal pathways such as Italy's *Decreto Flussi* and bilateral labour schemes are frequently repurposed by brokers, generating debt, misinformation, and false expectations. As high costs, low success rates, and weak accountability undermine trust in legal migration, irregular routes come to be seen not as unlawful choices but as rational responses to systems that are inaccessible in practice.

9.2.1 Lack of knowledge

Interviews reveal that most Bangladeshi migrants do not clearly distinguish between regular and irregular migration. For many, "legal" migration simply means travelling by plane with a valid passport, without full awareness of the administrative processes involved. This limited understanding, combined with widespread misinformation, leaves migrants vulnerable to manipulation. In the context of the hybrid system described earlier, where travel to Libya often begins through legal channels, the boundary between regular and irregular migration becomes particularly blurred. Several respondents reported only discovering that they were travelling irregularly once they reached Libya, where they were informed that the final leg to Italy would take place by boat.

9.2.2 Manipulation of legal migration systems

Italy's Decreto Flussi framework is the main legal mechanism through which non-EU nationals can enter Italy for work. It sets annual quotas for different sectors, such as agriculture, construction, and services, and applications are processed online during designated "click days" on a strictly first-come, first-served basis. Employers, or accredited intermediaries, must pre-compile applications on the government's ALI portal, and once the system opens, submissions are accepted in chronological order until the quota is filled. In practice, this creates a race to submit applications within seconds of the portal opening, and most slots are exhausted almost immediately.

While the system was designed to match labour demand with controlled migration, in reality it has become highly exclusionary and vulnerable to exploitation. The technical and bureaucratic complexity of the process, combined with the dependence on Italian employers to initiate applications, means that very few workers in Bangladesh can access it directly. Instead, intermediaries and private agencies act as gatekeepers. They present themselves as authorised facilitators of the decreto flussi, claiming they can secure nulla osta (work permits) or employer sponsorships for a fee.

These intermediaries frequently misuse or fabricate employer quotas. Some advertise non-existent Italian companies or claim to have secured quotas that were already filled, while others resell the same limited number of permits to multiple clients.

In Bangladesh, this system of deception has become deeply entrenched. Local recruitment agencies and dalals advertise the decreto flussi as a guaranteed opportunity for legal migration, circulating fake job offers, falsified company letters, and photocopies of genuine-looking Italian documents to reassure clients. Many set up temporary offices during click-day periods, claiming direct connections with Italian employers or "inside contacts" at embassies. Migrants, unable to verify the authenticity of these claims, often pay large sums in good faith, sometimes mortgaging land or borrowing heavily. In some cases, families receive fabricated receipts or screenshots of online submissions, giving the illusion that their applications are being processed in Italy. When months pass without updates, brokers blame embassy delays or administrative backlogs, sustaining the illusion for as long as possible.

The scale of the problem is reflected in Italy's own data. In 2024, only 7.8 per cent of assigned places under the decreto flussi resulted in completed work permits and stable jobs, and just 29 per cent of nulla osta led to visas being issued.[32] This demonstrates that there are serious structural issues within the system itself, which is creating the fertile ground for manipulation and exploitation.

32 ActionAid Italia (2025) Click day Decreto Flussi: i dati e le criticità. Available at: https://www.actionaid.it/press-area/click-day-decreto-flussi/

This vulnerability was underscored by the June 2025 Naples investigation, in which Italy's anti-mafia directorate (DDA) arrested 45 individuals (including three lawyers) on charges of using the click-day system to sell false documentation and fabricated job offers. Authorities seized luxury assets and €2 million in proceeds, describing the network as a "digital marketplace for illegal access to the quotas," where fake hires were created through ad hoc digital identities. The Italian Prime Minister publicly acknowledged that the operation exposed systemic abuse of the click-day channel.[33]

For Bangladeshi workers, these dynamics mean that even ostensibly legal migration routes operate through opaque, profit-driven intermediaries. The line between authorised and unauthorised recruitment has effectively collapsed, leaving migrants to navigate a formal system that, in practice, mirrors the logic of smuggling: pay an intermediary, wait in uncertainty, and hope that a place within the quota materialises.

9.2.2.1 MOU with Malaysia

The exploitation of legal migration systems is not unique to Italy; the Bangladesh–Malaysia labour corridor shows similar patterns. Under the 2012 G2G MoU, which was designed to cap worker fees at USD 420 and eliminate private intermediaries, migrants instead paid USD 3,900–6,000, facilitated by dalals who misrepresented jobs and wages. A 2023 Winrock study found extensive deception by recruitment agencies, while investigations uncovered fake employers, bribery-based approval of job orders, and widespread passport confiscation, with 72 per cent of workers reporting retention of documents. By 2025, Bangladesh had launched inquiries into agencies and former lawmakers implicated in collusion and embezzlement, demonstrating how state-to-state migration schemes can be hijacked by brokers, employers, and complicit officials.

9.2.2.2 Forced into irregular pathways

The other dimension that is relevant is that exploitation of regular migration systems can cause migrants to accumulate serious debts that become another driver for irregular migration. Most migrants borrow heavily to pay these fees, taking loans from local moneylenders, mortgaging family land, or selling livestock. They do so in the belief that once in Italy they will earn enough to repay the debt within months. When they later discover that their applications were fraudulent, or that no visa ever existed, they find themselves deeply indebted and socially disgraced, having already told their families and communities that they were migrating to Europe. At this point, many see no option but to pursue irregular channels, often turning to smugglers who promise to "complete" their journey through Libya.

Interviews reveal how these debts are structured at the community level. In rural areas, migrants often borrow from a village leader who functions as an informal moneylender, advancing funds specifically for migration-related expenses. The loans are given against the deed of the borrower's house or family land, and interest begins to accrue immediately. One respondent explained that he had borrowed from such a lender to pay both the migration fees and a later ransom payment. By the time of the interview, he had already repaid 500,000 taka (approx. USD 5 000) but still owed over 1 million (approx. USD 10 000), continuing to pay both interest and principal simultaneously. Crucially, these lenders only extend credit to people who are migrating, viewing migration as collateral; they would not lend to someone who stayed behind.

This dynamic creates a structural push factor toward irregular migration: once debt has been incurred on the assumption of departure, the borrower must migrate by any means to repay it. For many, therefore, irregular movement becomes not a choice but a financial necessity.

33 ANSA. (2025, June 10). Immigrazione clandestina, 45 arresti nel Napoletano. ANSA.it. Retrieved from https://www.ansa.it/campania/notizie/2025/06/10/immigrazione-clandestina-45-arresti-nel-napoletano_1164c288-c122-459e-9dce-9a57ea333729.html; Bozza, C. (2025, June 11). Sequestrati Ferrari e 2 milioni: sfruttavano l'immigrazione clandestina, raffica di arresti in Campania. Meloni: «Sui click day avevamo ragione». Corriere della Sera. Retrieved from https://www.corriere.it/politica/25_giugno_11/sequestrati-ferrari-e-2-milioni-sfruttavano-l-immigrazione-clandestina-45-arresti-in-campania-meloni-sui-click-day-avevamo-ragione-bce048b1-aceb-4ca6-817f-bf18d1697xlk.shtml

9.2.2.3 Accountability gaps

Within Bangladesh, the formal recruitment framework provides limited protection for workers who are defrauded or whose applications fail. By law, recruitment agencies must compensate clients when employment arrangements collapse, but in practice such complaints rarely reach the BMET. Most agencies settle disputes privately to avoid losing their licences or reputation, leaving the government with incomplete visibility over the scale of abuse. This lack of data makes it difficult to identify patterns of malpractice or to design effective regulatory responses.

9.2.3 When regular migration systems discourage legal migration

Even when no fraud is involved, the structure of legal migration systems itself can discourage migrants from pursuing regular pathways. As seen above through the Italian example, formal visa procedures, whether through embassy programmes, labour recruitment schemes, or bilateral agreements, are characterised by high administrative costs, long processing times, and very low success rates.

Applicants are required to pay substantial non-refundable fees when submitting their visa applications. These fees must be paid regardless of the outcome, and most applications are ultimately rejected. The process is also lengthy and opaque. Securing the necessary paperwork, such as invitation letters or sponsorship confirmations, can take months, followed by additional delays for verification and approval. Applicants receive little feedback on the status of their case, and many are never formally notified of rejection.

Because of these realities, even fully legitimate channels can leave migrants financially depleted and disillusioned. Many conclude that legal migration is not only expensive but also unattainable for ordinary workers. Smugglers and brokers exploit this perception, contrasting the slow, bureaucratic nature of official procedures with the speed and apparent certainty of irregular routes. They tell prospective migrants: “If you apply through the embassy, you will pay and wait forever; if you come with me, you will reach Italy in days.”

In this context, irregular migration becomes not a deliberate act of illegality but a rational response to systemic inefficiency and exclusion. The very design of formal migration systems, which are costly, complex, and inaccessible, creates conditions in which irregular routes appear faster, simpler, and more reliable, even for those who initially set out to migrate lawfully.

10. Perspectives and key take-aways

10.1 Migration from Bangladesh to Italy via Libya is a continuum, not a rupture

Migration from Bangladesh to Libya and Italy is best understood as the adaptive extension of long-standing labour migration systems rather than a rupture from them. The same brokers, documentation agents, and social trust structures that facilitate legal labour migration are repurposed to sustain irregular routes when regular pathways become inaccessible or unprofitable. This continuity underscores that irregular migration is not born of chaos but of structural limitations within formal systems, including costly and restrictive visa processes that leave aspiring workers few alternatives. The Libya corridor reflects how a well-established migration infrastructure can mutate to serve parallel, informal functions in response to both opportunity and constraint.

Implication: This suggests that protection-sensitive migration management should build on, rather than isolate from, these existing systems, improving oversight, integrity, and fairness in recruitment and documentation channels instead of approaching irregular migration as a detached criminal phenomenon.

10.2 Protection risks are embedded in formal systems

The report highlights that exploitation and deception occur not only along the smuggling route but within the formal recruitment system itself. Licensed intermediaries, sub-agents, and financiers in Bangladesh often replicate the same exploitative practices attributed to smugglers, such as inflated fees and false promises. Migrants' vulnerability is therefore institutionalised before departure, reinforced through debt and dependence that bind them to their brokers. Irregular movement becomes a continuation of exploitation rather than its starting point.

Implication: Efforts to enhance migrant protection may be most effective when focused on the recruitment and financing stage: by regulating intermediaries, ensuring full contract transparency, introducing targeted pre-departure counselling that demystifies hybrid routes, and strengthening financial literacy to reduce debt-based coercion.

10.3 Migrants' agency is real but constrained by systemic inequities

The decision to migrate irregularly emerges not from ignorance but from constrained rationality, a negotiation between aspiration, family pressure, and limited opportunity. Migrants are active decision-makers navigating systems stacked against them, weighing known risks against the perceived dignity of progress. Their choices are social, collective, and morally charged: refusing to migrate may mean disappointing family expectations or failing to repay communal loans. Within this structure, agency exists but operates under structural duress.

Implication: Migration management frameworks might become more effective if they acknowledge this constrained agency. Outreach and information efforts should not portray migrants as deceived or naïve but recognise the logic of their choices, supporting them through safer, affordable, and legitimate options that preserve dignity and social mobility.

10.4 Libya's hybrid migration system reflects governance gaps, not chaos

Eastern Libya's semi-formal visa and sponsorship regime demonstrates how migration management emerges in fragmented governance contexts. The system's functionality, with entry authorisations issued through the Military Investment Authority and local sponsors managing arrivals, shows a structured, revenue-generating model that fills the vacuum of absent national coordination. Far from anarchy, this represents an adaptive form of governance rooted in local authority and economic pragmatism.

Implication: Constructive engagement with Libyan authorities may therefore benefit from recognising and strengthening these emergent governance mechanisms. Rather than focusing solely on interdiction, partnerships could support standardisation, oversight, and human rights compliance within these local systems to promote stability and accountability.

10.5 The protection economy thrives on predictability and trust

Smuggling networks depend on the social and financial reliability of migrants' families, who act as predictable payers. Trust, in the broker, the process, and the promise of arrival, sustains the system. Families often guarantee repayment through social collateral and emotional obligation, making trust itself a tool of control. This "protection economy" thrives not through anonymity but through community legitimacy.

Implication: To reduce vulnerability, protection responses could target this trust-based architecture: expanding access to transparent credit and ethical lending, supporting family-level risk education, and developing safe community finance systems that reduce dependence on exploitative brokers.

10.6 Libya's conflict economy turns migrants into commodities

The Libyan context transforms migration into an economy of control. Fees for security clearance, passage, and detention releases flow directly into the coffers of armed groups and intermediaries. Migrants' presence is monetised at every stage, from recruitment to sea departure, thereby sustaining local economies of power. This dynamic blurs the line between state and militia, as control is exercised through formal procedures enforced by informal actors. Exploitation becomes systemic rather than incidental.

Implication: Migration partnerships and donor engagement in Libya could be strengthened by incorporating political economy and conflict analysis into programme design. This would ensure that migration management does not unintentionally reinforce the very power structures that profit from migrant vulnerability.

10.7 Smuggling and trafficking exist on a continuum

The boundaries between smuggling and trafficking in this corridor are porous. Migrants frequently move between voluntary facilitation and coercive exploitation depending on payment failure, capture, or debt escalation. These transitions are fluid and often shaped by circumstance, rather thannot intent. The legal separation between smuggling and trafficking thus obscures how exploitation actually unfolds on the ground.

Implication: Protection and legal frameworks could become more effective by adopting continuum-based approaches. This would involve linking anti-smuggling and anti-trafficking responses under shared coordination and ensuring that assistance is based on vulnerability and harm rather than rigid classifications.

10.8 The family is both protector and vector

Family networks sustain migration emotionally, financially, and logistically, but they can also amplify risk. Debt taken in the name of family honour or survival becomes a powerful coercive tool, compelling migrants to continue even when conditions deteriorate and risks increase. The same kinship systems that provide trust and solidarity can entrench cycles of pressure and silence around abuse.

Implication: Protection strategies could therefore incorporate family-oriented interventions, combining psychosocial counselling, remittance management guidance, and awareness of intergenerational pressures, to empower families as informed decision-makers rather than passive enablers of risk.

10.9 Diaspora networks shape both risk and resilience

The Bangladeshi diaspora in Italy operates as both an aspirational reference and a practical support structure. Success stories shared through social media reinforce migration aspirations, while established community members provide employment connections, shelter, and advice upon arrival. The diaspora thus forms a dual mechanism, driving mobility but also cushioning integration.

Implication: Migration management could more effectively engage diaspora communities as allies in protection and ethical recruitment. This could include structured mentorship programmes, support for community-based reintegration initiatives, and partnerships that channel remittances toward safe and legal mobility options.

10.10 Route-based protection requires multi-country governance

The Bangladesh–Libya–Italy corridor functions as an interdependent system spanning multiple jurisdictions, where interventions at one point reverberate across the chain. Crackdowns in Libya or new visa restrictions in the Gulf simply displace risk geographically. Uncoordinated national responses therefore perpetuate circular harm.

Implication: Comprehensive migration management could benefit from a route-based framework that connects origin, transit, and destination states through shared data, protection mechanisms, and mobility pathways. Such cooperation would integrate labour, humanitarian, and security dimensions to balance control with protection.

10.11 Information and empowerment, not deterrence

The study finds that deterrence campaigns fail because migrants are guided by social credibility, not official warnings. Trust flows through personal networks, and perceived success outweighs risk narratives. Deterrence alone cannot counteract the social legitimacy of migration.

Implication: Information strategies may be more effective when they focus on empowerment and credibility, using trusted voices such as returnees, community elders, or diaspora figures to communicate realistic costs and conditions, and framing migration choices in terms of agency rather than fear.

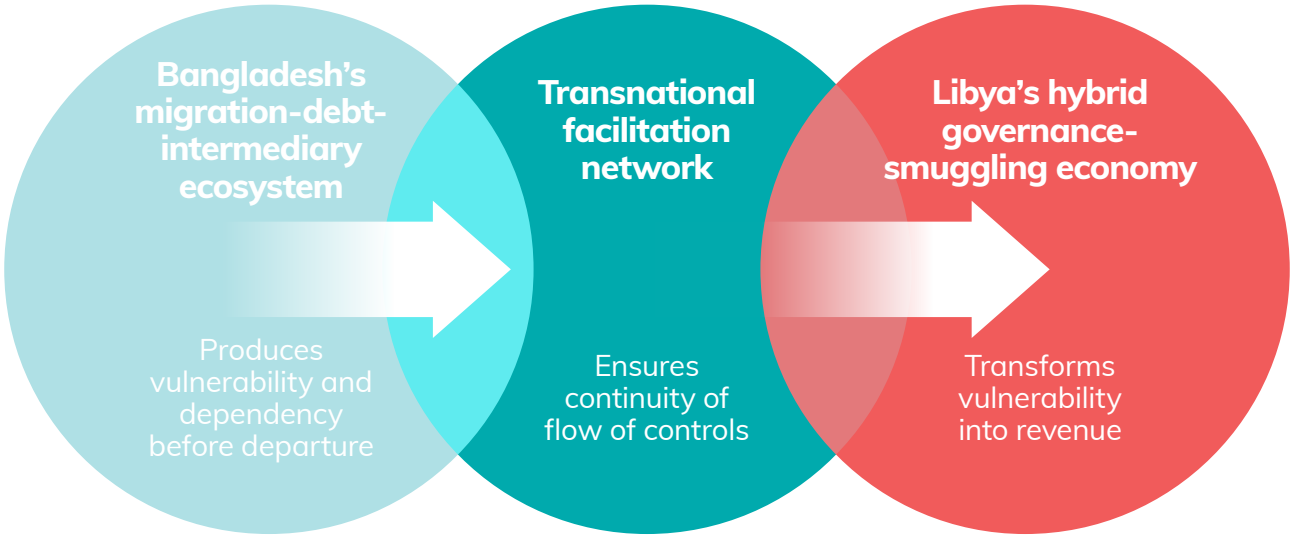
10.12 Governance must integrate economic, social, and humanitarian dimensions

Irregular migration persists because governance systems remain fragmented: labour, border, and protection institutions operate in silos, leaving space for intermediaries to thrive. The lack of cross-sector coordination reproduces vulnerability and erodes accountability.

Implication: Comprehensive migration management could advance by bridging these divides: aligning labour, security, and social protection frameworks through shared oversight and joint planning. Integrated governance would enable a more holistic approach that balances development, regulation, and rights.

11. Conclusion

Figure 17. Three interlocking systems driving migration from Bangladesh to Italy



Three interlocking systems underpinning the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy corridor

The findings of this study demonstrate that irregular migration from Bangladesh to Italy through Libya is not a disorderly or fragmented phenomenon. It is the outcome of three interlocking systems that together shape migrants' decisions, enable their movement, and produce the patterns of exploitation observed along the route. Understanding these systems as connected structures, rather than isolated events, offers a clearer view of why this corridor has expanded and why it has proven so resilient to policy interventions.

System 1. Bangladesh's migration–debt–intermediary ecosystem

Bangladesh's economy is structurally reliant on overseas employment, and migration is embedded in household strategies, community expectations, and national economic stability. Within this environment, a dense network of recruitment agencies, sub-agents, travel intermediaries, and informal lenders has emerged to facilitate mobility. These actors do not operate separately from irregular migration; rather, the same brokers who organise regular labour migration often work with irregular facilitators, using the infrastructure of legal mobility, such as passports, visas, and commercial flights, to initiate journeys that ultimately lead to Libya. High recruitment costs, widespread indebtedness, and limited transparency create the conditions in which migrants become dependent on intermediaries, making them more vulnerable to deception, coercion, and irregular pathways when regular options fail or become inaccessible. This system establishes the vulnerability profile that travels with migrants across borders.

System 2. The transnational facilitation network connecting Bangladesh to Libya

Movement out of Bangladesh is not characterised by illegal border crossings but by a modular chain of facilitators operating through Dubai, Egypt, Kuwait, India, Sri Lanka, Turkey, and formerly Syria. Each node manages one segment of the journey, such as documentation, airport passage, accommodation, or transit coordination, before handing migrants to the next. The route is highly adaptive: when scrutiny increases over flights to Dubai, brokers redirect travellers through India or Sri Lanka. This is not a single organisation but a distributed service economy responding to enforcement pressures and opportunities. The legality of the early stages of travel, the use of visas, flights, and formal documentation, obscures the point at which migration becomes irregular, blurring the line between authorised travel and broker-managed movement. This system ensures a reliable flow into Libya regardless of changing controls at origin or transit points.

System 3. Libya's hybrid governance–smuggling economy

Libya functions simultaneously as a destination for labour migrants, a transit point for those moving onward to Europe, and a political economy in which mobility itself is monetised. Since 2020, entry permissions issued in eastern Libya have allowed migrants to arrive legally at Benina Airport, where Bangladeshi and Libyan facilitators manage reception, registration, and movement across the east–west divide. Armed groups, local authorities, and coastal smuggling networks operate through a territorial handover model: eastern actors facilitate entry and westward passage; western coastal groups manage maritime departures. These are not competing structures but coordinated hubs in a larger economy in which each actor extracts revenue at its node. Shifts in enforcement; for example, crackdowns on eastern departures in late 2023, lead not to disruption but to internal re-routing, such as the transfer of migrants from Benghazi to Zuwara and Zawiya. Within this system, the boundary between smuggling and trafficking is fluid, shaped less by intent than by payment failure, delay, or capture. Extortion, debt bondage, and coercion are structural features, not aberrations.

Together, these three systems form a coherent architecture. Bangladesh's migration and debt dynamics create the conditions that drive people into the corridor; the transnational facilitation system moves them efficiently across borders; and Libya's hybrid governance economy absorbs them into a revenue-generating structure that channels them toward Italy. Each system reinforces the others, producing a high-throughput migration corridor that cannot be understood or addressed through interventions targeted at a single stage of the journey. Efforts to strengthen regular migration pathways, reduce debt-driven vulnerability, improve oversight of intermediaries, or support route-based protection mechanisms will only be effective if they recognise this systemic interdependence.

Ultimately, the Bangladesh–Libya–Italy corridor is not sustained by irregular actors alone, but by structural conditions, institutional gaps, and economic incentives that span origin, transit, and destination. A systems-based understanding of these dynamics is essential for developing migration policies that are both effective and protection-sensitive, and for designing responses that address not only the symptoms of irregular migration but the deeper structures that sustain it.



MMC is a knowledge centre engaged in data collection, research, analysis, and policy and programming on mixed migration. MMC has regional hubs in Africa, Asia, Europe, and Latin America, with a global team headquartered in Geneva, Switzerland, and based in several countries worldwide.

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